

AN M_{23} HURWITZ SCHEME: EXACT ARITHMETIC AND REDUCTION AT 23

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ABSTRACT. Huang, Jackson, Lee, Poonen, Pries, and Zhang constructed a degree-23 cover with regular Galois closure of group M_{23} and identified a Galois-fixed class in its seven-element inner Nielsen class. We reconstruct the associated finite étale Hurwitz scheme exactly. Over $K_0 = \mathbf{Q}(\sqrt{-23})$, its coordinate algebra is $K_0 \times L$, where $[L : K_0] = 6$, and the relative Galois closure of L/K_0 has group S_6 . Exact canonical models, degree-23 maps, and certified branch cycles realize all seven classes. A finite-group invariant and an idempotent obtained from pointed reduction at 23 both select the degree-six component; their equality follows from the certified branch-cycle matching. We give a coordinate-independent local interpretation of this idempotent: it is the complement of the Frobenius-fixed locus on the reduced closed fibre, and it lifts to the splitting locus of an unramified quadratic cover of the normalized integral model. An independent comparison by relative cohomological correspondences remains open. For the distinguished cover, we construct a minimal degree-4 projection and a primitive bidegree- $(23, 4)$ equation. The Fano plane and affine $\mathbf{F}_2^3$ -torsor in its branch fibre give a $2^4:\mathrm{PSL}_3(2)$ field tower. Finally, every integer specialization $t \equiv 2 \pmod{319}$ has Galois group M_{23} ; controlled ramification gives an infinite family for which every finite subfamily is linearly disjoint. Exact data and verification scripts accompany the results.

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1. INTRODUCTION

Seven covers with the same branch-cycle classes need not have the same arithmetic. In the construction of Huang et al. [1], the inner Nielsen class for $(2A, 23A, 23B)$ in M_{23} has seven elements. One class is fixed by the arithmetic Galois action considered there and gives their cover over $\mathbf{Q}$. Its Galois closure over $\mathbf{Q}(T)$ is regular: $\mathbf{Q}$ is algebraically closed in that function field. The existence and descent of this cover are therefore our starting point, not conclusions of the present paper.

We study the arithmetic of the entire seven-point Hurwitz scheme and its reduction at 23. The exact reconstruction separates a degree-one component from a degree-six component. A finite-group calculation and a pointed reduction calculation then define the same component idempotent. We prove this agreement by certified branch-cycle matching and give the local idempotent an interpretation in terms of Frobenius and an unramified quadratic extension.

Put $K_0 = \mathbf{Q}(\sqrt{-23})$, over which the ordered classes $23A, 23B$ are defined. The fixed class of [1] becomes the unique K_0 -rational point of the inner Hurwitz scheme below. Its further descent to a cover over $\mathbf{Q}$ remains the result of [1].

Theorem 1.1 (Exact arithmetic of the finite inner Hurwitz scheme). *Let $\mathcal{H}_{\text{in}}$ be the reduced inner Hurwitz scheme of normalized three-point covers with branch-cycle classes $(2A, 23A, 23B)$. There is a degree-6 field extension L/K_0 and an isomorphism*

$$\mathcal{H}_{\text{in}} \simeq \text{Spec}(K_0 \times L).$$

The relative Galois closure of L/K_0 has group S_6 . Over $\text{Spec}(K_0 \times L)$ there is an explicit family of canonical genus-4 curves equipped with degree-23 maps; its seven geometric fibres exhaust the seven Nielsen classes, and each map has monodromy M_{23} .

Thus the distinguished geometric point is the unique K_0 -rational point of $\mathcal{H}_{\text{in}}$; equivalently, it is the degree-one open-and-closed subscheme in the canonical $1 + 6$ decomposition. There are then two separately defined ways to detect its complement. The first uses the augmentation $\epsilon(\Theta)$ of a finite group-algebra element. The second evaluates a normalization parameter at a distinguished singular point of each pointed characteristic-23 reduction and gives an idempotent e_{sing} . Their comparison takes place in the exactly reconstructed coordinate algebra.

Theorem 1.2 (Agreement of the two component idempotents). *Let e_{sing} be the idempotent defined by the singular-point coordinate in proposition 3.10, and let $\epsilon(\Theta)$ be the augmentation of the group-algebra element Θ defined in Exact computation 3.11. Then*

$$\epsilon(\Theta) = e_{\text{sing}}$$

in the coordinate algebra of $\mathcal{H}_{\text{in}}$. Under the isomorphism $A_{\text{H}} = K_0 \times L$, both sides equal the primitive idempotent $e_6 = (0, 1)$.

Reduction at 23 gives the second idempotent a simple local interpretation. The normalized integral Hurwitz model has three closed points, with residue degrees 1, 2, 2 and ramification indices 1, 1, 2. The 23-power Frobenius fixes precisely the residue-degree-one component. Its complement is also the locus on which the unramified quadratic extension splits. These descriptions are independent of the chosen normalization coordinate. Theorem 3.13 gives the general local statement, and corollary 3.14 applies it to this model.

The finite-group invariant has a complementary interpretation inside the distinguished cover. Let $X \rightarrow \mathbf{P}_T^1$ be the degree-23 cover constructed in [1]. Its splitting field over $\mathbf{Q}(T)$ is regular with Galois group M_{23} , its source curve has genus 4, and its branch points are

$$0, \quad \sqrt{-23}, \quad -\sqrt{-23}.$$

The inertia involution at $T = 0$ has cycle shape $1^7 2^8$: seven sheets remain fixed and eight pairs collide. These two sets support respectively a Fano plane and an affine $\mathbf{F}_2^3$ -torsor. Their common odd fixed-point identity realizes the finite-group invariant as a finite incidence intersection. Extending this interpretation to a relative specialization argument remains open; section 3.6 explains why the elementary nearby-cycle calculation is insufficient.

The Fano plane contributes through this incidence calculation: it lies in the branch fibre of one cover, whereas the Hurwitz scheme parametrizes all seven covers.

To make the arithmetic within the distinguished cover exact, we also carry out the minimal-coordinate construction anticipated by Huang et al. Write $F(T, V) \in \mathbf{Z}[T, V]$ for their integral source equation.

Theorem 1.3 (Explicit realization of the minimal-degree projection). *There are explicit polynomials $J_0, J_1 \in \mathbf{Z}[T, V]$ and a primitive irreducible polynomial $P \in \mathbf{Z}[T, W]$ such that*

$$\deg_W P = 23, \quad \deg_T P = 4,$$

and, in $\mathbf{Q}(X)$,

$$W = \frac{J_0(T, V)}{J_1(T, V)}, \quad P(T, W) = 0, \quad \mathbf{Q}(T, W) = \mathbf{Q}(T, V).$$

Consequently P defines the same regular M_{23} -cover. The projection $X \rightarrow \mathbf{P}_W^1$ has degree 4, and therefore explicitly realizes the minimum over $\mathbf{Q}$ established in [1, Remark 3.4].

The coordinate change is regular across the structured branch fibre and preserves both of its residue fields.

Theorem 1.4 (Transport of the fibre above $T = 0$). *There are primitive irreducible polynomials $\tilde{H}_7, \tilde{R}_8 \in \mathbf{Z}[W]$ of degrees 7 and 8 such that*

$$\begin{aligned} F(0, V) &= 23^4 H_7(V) R_8(V)^2, \\ P(0, W) &= -23^3 \tilde{H}_7(W) \tilde{R}_8(W)^2. \end{aligned}$$

Moreover

$$\gcd(J_1(0, V), H_7(V) R_8(V)) = 1,$$

and substitution $W = J_0(0, V)/J_1(0, V)$ induces isomorphisms

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbf{Q}[W]/(\tilde{H}_7) &\xrightarrow{\sim} \mathbf{Q}[V]/(H_7), \\ \mathbf{Q}[W]/(\tilde{R}_8) &\xrightarrow{\sim} \mathbf{Q}[V]/(R_8). \end{aligned}$$

These isomorphisms give Galois-equivariant bijections between the respective sets of geometric roots.

Finally, the minimal equation has a separate global arithmetic application.

Theorem 1.5 (Uniform specialization). *For every integer*

$$t \equiv 2 \pmod{319},$$

the primitive part of $P(t, W)$ has degree 23, and its splitting field over $\mathbf{Q}$ has Galois group M_{23} in its natural degree-23 action.

Here and throughout, the phrase *fibre above the rational branch point* means the fibre of $X \rightarrow \mathbf{P}_T^1$ above $0 \in \mathbf{P}^1(\mathbf{Q})$; it does not assert that its points are $\mathbf{Q}$ -rational. This is a characteristic-zero branch fibre. We reserve *closed fibre* for a model over a local base and use *reduction* for passage modulo a prime.

The main argument is organized as follows:

degree-7 Hurwitz algebra $\longrightarrow$ seven exact maps and certified branch cycles $\longrightarrow \epsilon(\Theta) = e_{\text{sing}}$.

The pointed reduction at 23 independently constructs e_{sing} . Section 2 first compares the two idempotents and explains the scope of their comparison. The exact computations are followed by the local Frobenius criterion and the remaining obstacle to an independent geometric comparison. The minimal projection and branch-fibre arithmetic are supporting results on the distinguished cover, and the specialization theorem is an independent application.

1.1. Prior work and contributions. The regular M_{23} -cover, its source equation and branch cycles, the numerical computation of the seven complex covers, and the identification of the Galois-fixed Nielsen class are due to Huang et al. [1]. They also prove that the source curve has $\mathbf{Q}$ -gonality 4 and observe that a degree-4 coordinate could replace their degree-8 coordinate, without computing such a function. The branch-fibre and Hurwitz-scheme calculations in this paper begin from their cover and its accompanying data [2].

The braid-orbit calculation behind the seven-element Nielsen class goes back to Häfner [3]. The numerical three-point-cover method used by Huang et al. is that of Klug–Musty–Schiavone–Voight [4], implemented in the Belyi-map database of Musty–Schiavone–Sijlsing–Voight [5]. The point–line Gassmann pair and the flag description of transvections in $\text{PSL}_3(2)$ are standard. Likewise, the abstract solvability of the split embedding problem with abelian kernel is not at issue here [17]; our calculation identifies the fields cut out by this particular branch fibre. Huang et al. already obtain abstractly an infinite mutually independent family of M_{23} -extensions [1, Corollary 1.4(d)], and general Hilbert–Grünwald methods provide arithmetic progressions with prescribed specialization behavior [15, 16].

Relative to this prior work, the central contributions are the exact $K_0 \times L$ Hurwitz algebra, its S_6 Galois closure and seven exact maps, the characteristic-23 idempotent defined by the distinguished singularity, and its exact identification with the augmentation of Θ . We additionally interpret the local idempotent by Frobenius and unramified quadratic splitting, using standard facts about henselian rings and finite fields. This interpretation does not remove the branch-cycle identification from the comparison with Θ . Supporting results give the explicit minimal-degree equation and ruling field, the arithmetic and obstruction theory of the distinguished branch fibre, and the congruence class modulo 319 in which every specialization has group M_{23} , together with controlled ramification. The detailed attribution, limitations, and data provenance are recorded in section 9.

2. THE TWO COMPONENT IDEMPOTENTS

There are two primitive idempotents in

$$A_H = K_0 \times L : \quad e_1 = (1, 0), \quad e_6 = (0, 1).$$

The component comparison concerns two separately defined functions on the seven geometric points. The first is the augmentation $\epsilon(\Theta)$ of a group-algebra element in $\mathbf{F}_2[2^3:\mathrm{PSL}_3(2)]$. Its certified values are 0 on the distinguished Nielsen class and 1 on the other six. The second comes from the normalization of the integral Hurwitz scheme at the prime above 23. Evaluation at the distinguished singular point has polynomial

$$(u - 16)(u^2 + 1)(u^2 + u + 1),$$

and the function taking the values $(0, 1, 1)$ on these three closed points is e_{sing} .

The exact reconstruction identifies the seven maps with the seven Nielsen classes. It follows that both functions are e_6 , which proves theorem 1.2. The proof combines exact algebra with computational certificates. Its dependence on the branch-cycle matching is precise: that matching places the finite-group values on the two factors of $K_0 \times L$.

The local idempotent has a coordinate-independent description. Let R be the completion of the ring of integers of K_0 at its prime above 23, and normalize R in $A_H \otimes_{K_0} \mathrm{Frac} R$. Its reduced closed fibre has coordinate algebra

$$B \simeq \mathbf{F}_{23} \times \mathbf{F}_{23^2} \times \mathbf{F}_{23^2}.$$

The scheme-theoretic fixed locus of 23-power Frobenius is just the first factor. Its complementary idempotent lifts uniquely to e_6 . Equivalently, the unramified quadratic extension of R splits on precisely the other two components. We prove these assertions, including their general local form, in section 3.5.

Thus the singular-position calculation detects residue-field arithmetic, not merely the geometric type of the source singularity. The two E_8 reductions have different residue degrees and are distinguished by Frobenius. This is a local interpretation of the idempotent already computed, not a new proof of its agreement with the finite-group invariant.

For that stronger comparison, the Fano–affine odd fixed-point identity provides a finite incidence formula for $\epsilon(\Theta)$. However, in a finite pinching model the nearby-cycle stalk retains one basis vector per generic sheet, and its pairing is $\sum_e \alpha_e \beta_e$, not $(\sum_e \alpha_e)(\sum_e \beta_e)$. The integral quadratic identities recorded in section 3.6 do not construct a relative correspondence or a determinant line carrying the required extra data. A specialization proof identifying the two invariants without the certified branch-cycle matching remains an open question.

3. EXACT HURWITZ ARITHMETIC AND THE COMPONENT COMPARISON

3.1. Coordinate algebra and canonical models. We now turn to the seven-cover moduli problem itself. The section has three tasks: reconstruct and identify the finite Hurwitz scheme, construct its component idempotents independently from finite-group and characteristic-23 data, and compare them in the exact coordinate algebra. The normalized canonical quadric has the normalization-invariant coefficient

$$J = \frac{q_{13}}{A^2},$$

where A is the coefficient used to impose the fixed normalization in the accompanying data. Computing J at the seven analytic classes and reconstructing over K_0 gives a finite étale K_0 -algebra

$$A_H = K_0 \times L, \quad [L : K_0] = 6.$$

Let $\mathcal{H}_J = \text{Spec } A_H$. Its degree-one component carries the reconstructed map belonging to the distinguished class, and the six geometric points of its connected degree-six component carry the other six reconstructed maps. The branch-cycle computation below identifies $\mathcal{H}_J$ with the inner Hurwitz scheme $\mathcal{H}_{\text{in}}$.

Exact computation 3.1 (Coordinate algebra and canonical curves). The linear factor of the polynomial of J is

$$J - \frac{148227 - 34830\sqrt{-23}}{142129},$$

and its complementary factor is irreducible of degree 6 over K_0 . An absolute defining polynomial for L is

$$\begin{aligned} h(Z) = & Z^{12} - 6Z^{11} + 20Z^{10} - 32Z^9 + 44Z^8 - 22Z^7 + 6Z^6 \\ & - 22Z^5 + 44Z^4 - 32Z^3 + 20Z^2 - 6Z + 1. \end{aligned}$$

Over A_H , all ten coefficients of the canonical quadric, all twenty coefficients of a Petri cubic in the fixed coefficient normalization, and the two marked order-23 points reconstruct exactly. On each component the resulting quadric-cubic complete intersection is smooth.

The reciprocal form of h makes the Galois closure unexpectedly small to describe. Put

$$g(Y) = Y^6 - 6Y^5 + 14Y^4 - 2Y^3 - 27Y^2 + 44Y - 44.$$

Proposition 3.2 (Galois closure of the sextic component). *Let $E = \mathbf{Q}[Y]/(g)$ and let $\tilde{E}$ be its Galois closure. Then*

$$L = EK_0, \quad \text{Gal}(\tilde{E}/\mathbf{Q}) \cong S_6, \quad \text{Gal}(\tilde{E}K_0/K_0) \cong S_6,$$

and

$$\text{Gal}(\tilde{E}K_0/\mathbf{Q}) \cong S_6 \times C_2.$$

The relative Galois group acts as the full symmetric group on the six remaining maps. In the embedding order of Exact computation 3.6, its letters have Nielsen labels

$$(7, 4, 1, 5, 3, 2).$$

Moreover

$$\text{disc}(E) = 2^4 \cdot 11 \cdot 23^4, \quad \mathfrak{d}_{L/K_0} = (2^4 \cdot 11 \cdot 23).$$

Proof. Let a be the image of Z in $\mathbf{Q}[Z]/(h)$. The reciprocal-polynomial identity is

$$h(Z) = Z^6 g(Z + Z^{-1}).$$

The exact relative-to-absolute field map sends $\sqrt{-23}$ into $\mathbf{Q}(a)$, and the element $a + a^{-1} + \sqrt{-23}$ has degree 12 over $\mathbf{Q}$. Consequently $L = EK_0$. Maximal-order calculations give the displayed discriminants.

The rational primes 3, 139, 2671 split in K_0 , do not divide $\text{disc}(g)$, and give respective factor-degree patterns

$$(6), \quad (1, 5), \quad (1, 1, 1, 1, 2)$$

for g modulo those primes. Thus the relative Galois group contains a 6-cycle, a 5-cycle, and a transposition. The first factorization also proves irreducibility. Of the sixteen transitive subgroups of S_6 , only $6T16 = S_6$ contains all three cycle types.

Finally, the unique quadratic subfield of an S_6 splitting field is its discriminant field. Since

$$\text{disc}(g) = 2^{22} \cdot 11 \cdot 23^4,$$

that field is $\mathbf{Q}(\sqrt{11})$, rather than $K_0 = \mathbf{Q}(\sqrt{-23})$. Therefore $\tilde{E}$ and K_0 are linearly disjoint, giving the two asserted Galois groups. The labeling by Nielsen classes is obtained from the certified branch-cycle continuation. $\square$

3.2. Reconstruction and identification of the seven maps. We now pass from the reconstructed coordinate algebra to the maps themselves. The analytic calculation supplies a uniform error bound; exact canonical-ring linear algebra then reconstructs the ratios, and certified branch cycles identify their moduli points.

Exact computation 3.3 (Uniform truncation-error certificate). The 47 chart centres cover both half-triangles with pseudohyperbolic radius less than 0.471: an Arb calculation [10] on geodesically convex mesh cells in the Klein disk model gives the upper bound 0.4708683715. At Cauchy radius $\rho = 0.72$, the modes $0, \dots, 60$, augmented by four normalization rows, have certified minimum singular value at least $6.60 \cdot 10^{-4}$ in all seven classes. Let A be the augmented low-mode matrix, h the norm bound for the high-mode operator, and ℓ the bound for the low-mode transition operator. Parseval gives $h \leq 2.35 \cdot 10^{-11}$ and $\ell \leq 1.38 \cdot 10^3$, so the explicitly defined Schur-complement margin

$$m = \sigma_{\min}(A) - \frac{h\ell}{1-h}$$

is positive in every class.

A bootstrap using Cauchy estimates at outer radius 0.99 bounds the exact normalized forms. The final $N = 700$, $Q = 1280$ Arb calculation then evaluates all 1280 discrete Fourier transform (DFT) output modes, not only those through the polynomial cutoff. Combining its residual balls with the certified inverse and branch-jet conditioning gives at least 75 certified decimal digits in each of the first twenty branch-normalized Taylor rows used to recover the canonical quadric and Petri cubic.

The exact equations are too large to reproduce usefully in print. They are stored in power or integral bases in `hurwitz_canonical_models_candidate.json` and `hurwitz_marked_points_candidate.json`. Their importance here is that they allow the covering function to be recovered by linear algebra internal to the canonical ring, with no search for a low-degree plane ansatz.

Proposition 3.4 (Exact degree-23 ratios). *Let $C \rightarrow \text{Spec } A_H$ be the reconstructed family of canonical complete intersections, and let $b, c : \text{Spec } A_H \rightarrow C$ be the two sections marking the points with order-23 inertia. There are explicit quintic canonical sections N, D such that*

$$u = \frac{N}{D}, \quad \text{div}(u) = 23b - 23c.$$

In particular u has degree 23 on every geometric fibre. Restriction to the degree-6 factor of A_H and its six K_0 -embeddings gives six explicit conjugate maps.

Proof. The degree-5 piece of the canonical ring has dimension 27. The first 23 local coefficients at either marked point have rank 23, and hence

$$B = H^0(5K_C - 23b), \quad C' = H^0(5K_C - 23c)$$

both have dimension 4. The degree-10 piece has dimension 57. Multiplication there turns the identities

$$B_i(MC')_j - B_j(MC')_i = 0 \quad (0 \leq i < j \leq 3)$$

into a linear system with 16 unknowns. Its rank is 15; its kernel is generated by an invertible matrix M . The deterministic first row gives $N = B_0$ and $D = (MC')_0$. Exact local expansions give

$$\text{ord}_b(N) = 23, \quad D(b) \neq 0, \quad \text{ord}_c(D) = 23, \quad N(c) \neq 0.$$

Finally, saturating the ideal generated by the four sections of B away from b gives the unit ideal, and the same calculation for MC' away from c again gives the unit ideal. Thus the two linear systems have no base points away from b and c . Together with the displayed local orders, the fixed divisors of these complete linear systems are exactly $23b$ and $23c$. Write $G_i = (MC')_i$. The multiplication identities imply $B_i = uG_i$ for one rational function $u = N/D$. Taking the minimum of the orders over i at every point gives

$$\text{div}(u) = 23b - 23c.$$

The chosen sections themselves do have a common effective divisor:

$$\text{div}(N) = 23b + E, \quad \text{div}(D) = 23c + E, \quad \deg E = 7.$$

Indeed, a quintic canonical section has degree $5(2g - 2) = 30$, so the common divisor is necessary. Cancelling it gives the asserted degree-23 map. $\square$

It remains to put the third branch point at 1. The raw value is $\lambda = u(a) \in L$, where a is any point above the order-2 branch point. Its coordinates in the chosen power basis have a large common denominator, so ordinary coordinatewise recognition is ineffective.

Exact computation 3.5 (Third branch normalization). At 71 rational primes splitting completely in L , the unique nonzero linear factor of multiplicity 8 in the reduced branch discriminant is computed in all twelve residue embeddings and interpolated into the power basis. Their CRT modulus has 404 decimal digits. A 13-dimensional LLL calculation [9] gives a 1129-bit common-denominator vector; the next lattice vectors have at least 1246 bits. This value agrees with the independent 1024-bit Arb computation to $1.7 \cdot 10^{-101}$ in integral-basis coordinates. It also agrees exactly at 24 further completely split primes that were withheld from CRT and LLL.

For a characteristic-zero check, project the canonical complete intersection birationally to a plane sextic. After cancellation, N and D become plane forms of degree 7. The resultants of the plane sextic with a generic fibre and with $N - \lambda D$ both have degree 42. Their gcds with their x -derivatives have degrees 6 and 14, respectively; the common factor has degree 6, and the additional degree-8 quotient is squarefree. The only other possible source of such a repeated projected root is two distinct plane points with the same x -coordinate. Magma excludes this after good reduction at the completely split prime 863153: in residue embeddings 2, 3, 4, 5, 9, 12, every irreducible factor of the degree-8 quotient gives a degree-1 gcd in the remaining coordinate. Since the resultant, gcd, and squarefree-factor degrees are preserved, a characteristic-zero common divisor of degree at least 2 would remain one after reduction. Thus the third fibre has eight distinct double points and seven simple points. Independently, the projective critical ideal has length $15 = 7 + 8$ in all twelve residue embeddings.

With this value, the six maps are normalized by

$$\beta = \frac{N}{\lambda D};$$

their branch values are $0, 1, \infty$, with passport

$$(23), \quad (2^8 1^7), \quad (23).$$

The exact field element λ , all reconstruction and holdout residues, and the sparse sections $N, D, \lambda D$ are stored in `hurwitz_degree23_branch_candidate.json` and `hurwitz_degree23_maps_candidate.json`. The degree and the two totally ramified fibres in proposition 3.4 are characteristic-zero exact statements, as is the third-fibre multiplicity in Exact computation 3.5. The uniform Taylor-tail estimate is supplied by Exact computation 3.3. The filenames retain the word *candidate* to record that LLL and bounded-denominator reconstruction were the discovery route for the displayed coefficients; the following independent cover identification removes that reconstruction assumption from the final Hurwitz-algebra statement.

Exact computation 3.6 (Exact eliminant and certified branch cycles). In the affine canonical chart $X_0 = 1$, eliminate $X_3 = z$ from the quadric and Petri cubic. If their linear subresultant is $L_1(x, y)z + L_0(x, y)$, then every serialized quintic is linear in z , so a section $S_0 + zS_1$ becomes the degree-7 plane form $S_0L_1 - S_1L_0$. Eliminating y from the plane sextic and $N - t\lambda D$ gives a raw resultant $R_t(x)$ of degree 42. The exact gcd of R_2 and R_3 has degree 19 and divides every R_t ; after division, the values at $t = 2, \dots, 8$ interpolate

$$P(t, x) \in L[t, x], \quad \deg_t P = 6, \quad \deg_x P = 23.$$

The unused value $t = 9$ agrees exactly. At $t = 0, 1, \infty$, the gcds with the x -derivative have degrees 22, 8, 22, and the degree-8 gcd is squarefree.

For each of the six embeddings of L over the chosen embedding of K_0 , Arb isolates the 23 roots over $t_* = 1/2 + 2i$ and continues them around rational polygonal loops about $0, 1, \infty$. On every straight path segment, each sheet is enclosed in a disk of radius R with fixed inverse slope Y . Writing

$$\eta = \sup |YP(t, c)|, \quad q = \sup |1 - YP_x(t, x)|,$$

the segment is accepted only when $q < 1$ and $\eta + qR < R$, all 23 disks are pairwise disjoint, and the endpoint root balls lie in their unique disks. Otherwise the segment is bisected. Thus the continuation is certified by a uniform contraction, not by nearest-neighbour matching. The map on the degree-one component (Nielsen class 6) is checked independently from its integral minimal-degree equation by the same method.

The full run contains 150145 accepted tubes and has maximum dyadic depth 18. In the sextic-embedding order the Nielsen IDs are

$$(7, 4, 1, 5, 3, 2).$$

Together with the independently checked degree-one map, whose Nielsen ID is 6, the seven triples have cycle shapes

$$(23), \quad (1^7 2^8), \quad (23),$$

their products are the identity, and every pair generates a permutation group of order 10200960. After conjugating the order-23 generator to the fixed y , centralizer translation matches the seven involutions with Nielsen representatives $1, \dots, 7$, exactly once each. The independent normalization of the degree-one map orders the two order-23 endpoints oppositely, so its comparison uses the inverse of its loop about 0.

Corollary 3.7 (Identification of the finite Hurwitz scheme). *The finite étale scheme $\mathcal{H}_J = \text{Spec}(K_0 \times L)$ is isomorphic to $\mathcal{H}_{\text{in}}$. Thus $A_H = K_0 \times L$ is the coordinate algebra of the finite inner Hurwitz scheme of degree 7 and type $(2A, 23A, 23B)$. In particular, all seven reconstructed maps have monodromy M_{23} .*

Proof. The group-side Nielsen calculation gives exactly seven inner classes. Exact computation 3.6 produces one exact cover in each of them. They are therefore distinct and exhaustive. The induced map between the two reduced finite étale K_0 -schemes is a bijection on geometric points, hence an isomorphism. This identifies the coordinate algebra without an a priori height bound for the preceding LLL discovery. $\square$

Proof of theorem 1.1. The coordinate algebra and smooth canonical curves are given by Exact computation 3.1. The exact maps are constructed in proposition 3.4 and Exact computation 3.5; their certified branch cycles give the identification with $\mathcal{H}_{\text{in}}$ in Exact computation 3.6 and corollary 3.7. Finally, proposition 3.2 proves the S_6 assertion. $\square$

3.3. Local structure at 23. The prime above 23 gives a particularly small local realization of this full symmetric action. Let $\mathfrak{q} = (\sqrt{-23})$ be the unique prime of K_0 above 23.

Proposition 3.8 (Local Hurwitz algebra at 23). *The normalization of $\text{Spec } \mathcal{O}_{K_0, \mathfrak{q}}$ in $A_H = K_0 \times L$ has three closed points. Their ramification indices and residue degrees over $K_{0, \mathfrak{q}}$ are*

$$(e, f) = (1, 1), \quad (1, 2), \quad (2, 2),$$

where the first point lies on the degree-one component and the other two lie on the sextic component. In the S_6 -closure, a decomposition group at $\mathfrak{q}$ is

$$D_{\mathfrak{q}} \cong V_4.$$

Its natural action on the six remaining points has orbits of sizes 2 and 4; inertia has cycle type $1^2 2^2$, and either lift of residue Frobenius has cycle type 2^3 .

Proof. Modulo 23 the trace sextic satisfies

$$g(Y) = (Y - 5)^2(Y + 1)^4.$$

Over $\mathbf{Q}_{23}$ its two factors have degrees 2 and 4. Their discriminant valuations are 1 and 3, with residual units 9 and 7; their discriminant square classes are therefore 23 and -23 . The quartic factor is totally tamely ramified. Its local Galois closure is dihedral of order 8: tame inertia is cyclic of order 4, while Frobenius acts by inversion because $23 \equiv -1 \pmod{4}$. Its discriminant field is $\mathbf{Q}_{23}(\sqrt{-23})$. Restriction to $K_{0, \mathfrak{q}}$ gives the even Klein four subgroup. The quadratic factor field is $\mathbf{Q}_{23}(\sqrt{23})$; its compositum with $K_{0, \mathfrak{q}}$ is the same unramified quadratic field already contained in the dihedral closure. This gives the asserted group action and prime data.

The first residual equations make the common residue field explicit. If $s = \sqrt{-23}$, then

$$U = \frac{Y - 5}{s}, \quad \bar{U}^2 = 15, \quad V = \frac{(Y + 1)^2}{s}, \quad \bar{V}^2 = 5.$$

Both equations define $\mathbf{F}_{23^2}$, since $15/5 = 3 = 7^2$ in $\mathbf{F}_{23}$. $\square$

A complex Nielsen labeling of the local $2 + 4$ partition is not canonical: it requires choosing a prime of the S_6 -closure above $\mathfrak{q}$, and changing that prime conjugates $D_{\mathfrak{q}}$ inside S_6 .

We use the standard ADE nomenclature and the Milnor, Tjurina, and delta invariants as in [11].

Exact computation 3.9 (Pointed closed fibres at 23). The exact canonical equations, marked points, and degree-23 map sections are integral at each of the three closed points of the normalized local Hurwitz scheme. The resulting closed fibres are geometrically integral quadric–cubic complete intersections, their canonical quadrics remain smooth, and the marked zero b and pole c remain distinct smooth points. Their singularities are

closed point	residue field	singularities
degree-one point (class 6)	$\mathbf{F}_{23}$	E_8
point with $(e, f) = (1, 2)$	$\mathbf{F}_{23^2}$	E_8
point with $(e, f) = (2, 2)$	$\mathbf{F}_{23^2}$	$A_2 + A_6$.

The Milnor and Tjurina numbers are respectively 8, and $2 + 6$. In each row the total delta invariant is 4, so the geometric normalization is $\mathbf{P}^1$.

Let N, D be the reduced quintic map sections. Their common base scheme has length 7, avoids the singular points, and

$$\text{ord}_b(N) = \text{ord}_c(D) = 23, \quad \text{ord}_b(D) = \text{ord}_c(N) = 0.$$

Consequently, on the normalization,

$$\text{div}(N/D) = 23b - 23c.$$

There is a unique coordinate t on the normalization with $b = 0$, $c = \infty$, and

$$\bar{\beta} = t^{23}$$

at all three closed points.

Proof. Exact reduction in the two residue fields gives the displayed singular loci and no singularity at infinity. Eliminating the smooth-quadric coordinate gives an irreducible plane sextic. The exact local plane equations have triple tangent, Milnor–Tjurina pair $(8, 8)$, and fifth-order tangent restriction in the first two cases, identifying E_8 in characteristic 23. At the third point the two completed local equations have Milnor–Tjurina pairs $(2, 2)$ and $(6, 6)$ and critical-value orders 3 and 7, identifying A_2 and A_6 . Their delta invariants exhaust the arithmetic genus 4. The common base ideal has constant Hilbert polynomial 7, and exact local series at b, c give the four displayed orders. Since the residue fields are perfect, the remaining scalar multiplying t^{23} can be absorbed into t . The resulting coordinate is unique, since $a^{23} = 1$ in characteristic 23 implies $a = 1$. $\square$

These pointed closed fibres contain more arithmetic information than their ADE types alone. If P is one of the three closed points, let τ_P be the unique singularity in the E_8 cases and the uniquely characterized A_6 singularity in the third case. Both are unibranch. We may therefore evaluate the normalization coordinate at the point above τ_P .

Proposition 3.10 (Idempotent defined by the normalized singularity coordinate). *Put $u(P) = t(\tau_P)$. On the reduced closed fibre of the normalized local Hurwitz scheme, u is a primitive element of its coordinate algebra, with minimal polynomial*

$$R_{23}(u) = (u - 16)(u^2 + 1)(u^2 + u + 1) = 0.$$

The linear factor is the degree-one E_8 point, the factor $u^2 + 1$ is the unramified quadratic E_8 point, and $u^2 + u + 1$ is the ramified $A_2 + A_6$ point. In

$$B = \mathbf{F}_{23}[u]/(R_{23})$$

the polynomial

$$e_{\text{sing}}(u) = 2u^4 + 2u^3 + 4u^2 + 2u + 3$$

is idempotent and has values $(0, 1, 1)$ on these three factors. Its unique lift to the completed local Hurwitz algebra is the sextic component idempotent $e_6 = (0, 1)$. In particular,

$$e_{\text{sing}}(P) = f(P) - 1 \pmod{2}.$$

Proof. Exact evaluation on the normalizations gives

closed point	$u(P)$	minimal polynomial over $\mathbf{F}_{23}$
degree one, E_8	16	$u - 16$
E_8 , $(e, f) = (1, 2)$	$\sqrt{-1}$	$u^2 + 1$
A_6 , $(e, f) = (2, 2)$	r	$r^2 + r + 1$.

In the last row the A_2 point has parameter $t = 1$, while Frobenius exchanges r and r^2 . The constructions of t and τ_P commute with residue-field automorphisms, so the displayed values define an element of the coordinate algebra of the reduced closed fibre. The three factors are pairwise coprime, and their degrees sum to the five geometric points of that fibre, proving the primitive-coordinate assertion.

If $A = (u^2 + 1)(u^2 + u + 1)$, then $A(16) = 11$ and $11^{-1} = 21$ in $\mathbf{F}_{23}$. Hence

$$e_{\text{sing}} = 1 - 21A = 1 + 2A,$$

which gives both its displayed formula and its three values. Idempotents lift uniquely through nilpotent thickenings and complete local rings. The two quadratic factors are precisely the two local factors of L , so the lift is e_6 . $\square$

Thus the characteristic-23 models themselves construct the morphism to the constant two-point scheme that cuts out the degree-six component; no complex Nielsen labels or continued branch cycles enter proposition 3.10. This construction alone does not yet identify the two expressions

$$\epsilon(\Theta) = e_{\text{sing}}.$$

The exact branch-cycle certificate proves the equality indirectly because both sides are e_6 ; this is the proof used in theorem 1.2. Section 3.6 then asks whether the equality can also be obtained from a single specialization argument. Resolving only the coarse ADE source is insufficient: the degree-one and unramified quadratic reductions both have geometric type E_8 . A successful geometric proof must retain the arithmetic singular position together with compatible incidence and gluing data.

3.4. Descent of finite invariants. We first specify what *descent* means here. For a finite set S , let $\underline{S}_{K_0} = \coprod_{s \in S} \text{Spec } K_0$ be the associated constant finite étale scheme. An assignment

$$f : \mathcal{H}_{\text{in}}(\overline{K}_0) \longrightarrow S$$

descends over K_0 if it is invariant under $\text{Gal}(\overline{K}_0/K_0)$, equivalently if it is induced by a K_0 -morphism $\mathcal{H}_{\text{in}} \rightarrow \underline{S}_{K_0}$. When $S = \{0, 1\}$, such morphisms are equivalent to idempotents of the coordinate algebra $A_{\mathbb{H}}$.

We next define the finite-group assignments to be tested. Let $G = M_{23}$, let (x, y, z) be one of the seven normalized triples, and put $Y = \langle y \rangle$ and $Z = \langle z \rangle$. The two-endpoint order count is

$$\nu(Y, Z) = \#\{(a, b) \in (\mathbf{F}_{23}^\times)^2 : \text{ord}(y^a z^b) = 23\}.$$

For $c \in \{y, z\}$ and $d \in \mathbf{F}_{23}^\times$, put

$$a_c(d) = \text{ord}(xx^{c^d}), \quad \kappa_m = \sum_{c \in \{y, z\}} \#\{d \in \mathbf{F}_{23}^\times : a_c(d) = m\} \quad (m = 2, 4).$$

Changing a generator of Y or Z only reindexes the exponents, and the sum over $c \in \{y, z\}$ is unchanged when the two endpoints are exchanged.

Write $N(Y) = N_G(Y)$, use the convention $x^g = g^{-1}xg$, and set

$$\Omega = x^{N(Y)} \cap x^{N(Z)}.$$

The stabilizer of x in either normalizer is trivial: its order divides both $|N_G(Y)| = 253$ and $|C_G(x)| = 2688$. Thus, for $w \in \Omega$, the transporter sets from x to w in $N(Y)$ and $N(Z)$ are singletons; denote their elements by $n_Y(w)$ and $n_Z(w)$. Their relative comparison

$$c_w = n_Y(w)n_Z(w)^{-1}$$

centralizes x . Let A_x be the set of eight two-element orbits of $\langle x \rangle$ on the moved letters. The induced permutation $\bar{c}_w$ lies in

$$C_G(x)/\langle x \rangle \cong 2^3 : \text{PSL}_3(2) \cong \text{AGL}(3, 2),$$

acting faithfully on A_x . Define

$$\mu = \#\{\bar{c}_w : w \in \Omega\}, \quad \Theta = \sum_{w \in \Omega} [\bar{c}_w] \in \mathbf{F}_2[C_G(x)/\langle x \rangle].$$

Finally, let ϵ be the standard augmentation homomorphism of this group algebra. Then $\epsilon(\Theta) = |\Omega| \bmod 2$. The Hamming weight $\text{wt}(\Theta)$ is the number of nonzero coefficients of Θ in the group basis.

Exact computation 3.11 (Descent of the transporter invariants). In the sextic embedding order $(7, 4, 1, 5, 3, 2)$, the exact values of the two-endpoint order count ν , the affine-image count μ , and the Hamming weight of Θ are respectively

$$\begin{aligned} \nu|_L &= (42, 46, 54, 46, 28, 54), \\ \mu|_L &= (14, 28, 16, 28, 31, 16), \\ \text{wt}(\Theta)|_L &= (11, 27, 15, 27, 25, 15). \end{aligned}$$

The cyclic-conjugacy order counts (κ_2, κ_4) are likewise

$$((4, 12), (2, 6), (0, 16), (2, 6), (0, 8), (0, 16)).$$

None is constant. By contrast,

$$\epsilon(\Theta)|_L = (1, 1, 1, 1, 1, 1), \quad \epsilon(\Theta)|_{K_0} = 0.$$

Moreover, on all seven geometric points,

$$\mathbf{1}_{\{\nu=32\}} = \mathbf{1}_{\{\mu=17\}} = \mathbf{1}_{\{(\kappa_2, \kappa_4)=(0,12)\}} = \mathbf{1}_{\{\epsilon(\Theta)=0\}}.$$

Proposition 3.12 (Component idempotents detected by finite invariants). *Let $e_1 = (1, 0)$ and $e_6 = (0, 1)$ be the primitive idempotents of $A_H = K_0 \times L$. The four $\{0, 1\}$ -valued assignments in Exact computation 3.11 descend to morphisms to $\underline{\{0, 1\}}_{K_0}$ and all correspond to e_1 ; the augmentation corresponds to $e_6 = 1 - e_1$.*

The assignments ν , μ , and (κ_2, κ_4) do not descend on $\text{Spec } L$ to morphisms into the corresponding constant finite schemes. Moreover Θ cannot descend as a section of a lisse $\mathbf{F}_2$ -sheaf whose transition maps permute the natural group-algebra basis.

Proof. Because L is a field, $\text{Spec } L$ is connected. Every morphism from it to a constant finite étale scheme is therefore constant, whereas the displayed values of the three assignments vary among its six geometric points. A permutation of the group-algebra basis preserves Hamming weight, so the varying weights also rule out the stated basis-compatible descent of Θ . The four equality predicates are 1 only at ID 6, while the augmentation is 1 precisely on the other six points. Under the correspondence between morphisms to the constant two-point scheme and idempotents, they are therefore e_1 and e_6 , respectively. $\square$

This interpretation uses the certified $1 + 6$ decomposition and the exact branch-cycle identification of its seven geometric points.

Proof of theorem 1.2. By proposition 3.10, evaluation at the distinguished singularity defines $e_{\text{sing}} = e_6$. By proposition 3.12, the augmentation is $\epsilon(\Theta) = e_6$. Hence $\epsilon(\Theta) = e_{\text{sing}}$ in A_H . $\square$

3.5. Frobenius and unramified extensions. We give a coordinate-independent interpretation of the local idempotent. The general facts used here are standard properties of finite fields and henselian rings; the application identifies what the singular-position calculation measures in this particular Hurwitz scheme.

Theorem 3.13 (Local component criterion). *Let R be the ring of integers of a nonarchimedean local field F , with residue field $k = \mathbf{F}_q$. Let A be a finite normal flat R -algebra with étale generic fibre, and write*

$$A = \prod_i O_i, \quad B = (A/\mathfrak{m}_R A)_{\text{red}} = \prod_i \mathbf{F}_{q^{f_i}}.$$

Here O_i is the ring of integers of a field extension of F with ramification index e_i and residue degree f_i .

- (1) *The scheme-theoretic fixed locus of the q -power Frobenius on $\text{Spec } B$ is open and closed, consisting precisely of the factors with $f_i = 1$. It lifts uniquely to an open-and-closed subscheme $Z \subset \text{Spec } A$, finite flat over R of rank $\sum_{f_i=1} e_i$. In particular, $Z \simeq \text{Spec } R$ if and only if there is exactly one index with $f_i = 1$ and that index has $e_i = 1$.*
- (2) *Let R_m/R be the unramified extension of degree $m \geq 1$. On the connected component $\text{Spec } O_i$, its pullback is the split degree- m cover if and only if $m \mid f_i$. Thus the union of the components on which it splits is canonically open and closed.*

These constructions are invariant under R -algebra isomorphisms of A .

Proof. The fixed locus is the equalizer of Frobenius and the identity, so its coordinate ring is

$$B/(b^q - b : b \in B).$$

In a field factor $\mathbf{F}_{q^{f_i}}$ this ideal is zero if $f_i = 1$. Otherwise there is an element not fixed by q -power Frobenius; its nonzero difference is a unit, so that factor of the quotient is zero. This proves the

description of the fixed locus. Notice that it is a quotient algebra, not the invariant subalgebra B^{Frob_q} .

Idempotents lift uniquely through nilpotent ideals and from the closed fibre of a finite algebra over a complete local ring [19, Tags 09XD and 04GK]. This proves existence and uniqueness of Z . Each O_i is free over R of rank $e_i f_i$, which gives the stated rank. A factor of rank one has fraction field F and hence is R .

The residue algebra of $O_i \otimes_R R_m$ at the maximal ideal of O_i is $\mathbf{F}_{q^{f_i}} \otimes_{\mathbf{F}_q} \mathbf{F}_{q^m}$. As an algebra over $\mathbf{F}_{q^{f_i}}$, this is a product of $\gcd(f_i, m)$ fields, each of degree $m/\gcd(f_i, m)$. It is therefore split exactly when $m \mid f_i$. Finite étale algebras over the henselian local ring O_i are determined by their residue algebras [19, Tag 04GK], so the same criterion holds over O_i . The descriptions use neither coordinates nor labels of the factors, proving the last assertion. $\square$

The two criteria in the theorem are not equivalent in general. For example, an odd residue degree greater than one gives neither a Frobenius-fixed point nor splitting of the unramified quadratic extension. They are complementary when every residue degree is either one or two.

Corollary 3.14 (The characteristic-23 component). *Let $R = \widehat{\mathcal{O}}_{K_0, \mathfrak{q}}$, where $\mathfrak{q}$ is the prime above 23, and let A be the normalization of R in $A_{\mathbf{H}} \otimes_{K_0} \text{Frac } R$. The complement of the Frobenius-fixed locus on its reduced closed fibre lifts to the component idempotent e_6 . Equivalently, e_6 is the idempotent of the locus on which the finite étale double cover*

$$\text{Spec}(A[z]/(z^2 + 1)) \longrightarrow \text{Spec } A$$

splits. In the singular-position coordinate of proposition 3.10, its reduction is

$$e_{\text{sing}} = -(u^{23} - u)^{22} = 2u^4 + 2u^3 + 4u^2 + 2u + 3 \quad \text{in } \mathbf{F}_{23}[u]/(R_{23}).$$

Proof. The exact local decomposition has pairs $(e_i, f_i) = (1, 1), (1, 2), (2, 2)$. The first factor comes from K_0 and the other two from L . Thus theorem 3.13 identifies the Frobenius-fixed component with the R factor and its complement with the localization of L .

Since -1 is not a square in $\mathbf{F}_{23}$, $R[z]/(z^2 + 1)$ is the unramified quadratic extension of R . Its discriminant is a unit. It is nonsplit on the first factor and split on the other two, by the same theorem.

Finally, let $\delta = u^{23} - u$. It is zero in the linear factor. In each quadratic factor u generates the residue field, so $\delta \neq 0$ and $\delta^{23} = -\delta$. Consequently $\delta^{22} = -1$ there. Thus $-\delta^{22}$ has values $(0, 1, 1)$, as does the displayed polynomial. The Chinese remainder theorem proves their equality. $\square$

This gives an actual finite étale cover of the normalized integral Hurwitz scheme, not just a list of three matching values. Its split locus is defined without the chosen coordinate u . The singular-position polynomial is an explicit presentation of that locus. Combining corollary 3.14 with the certified branch-cycle matching gives

$$\epsilon(\Theta) = e_6 = e_{\text{sing}}.$$

The construction of the local locus does not use that matching; the comparison with $\epsilon(\Theta)$ still does.

There are two essential limitations. First, the residue field is part of the statement: replacing q -power Frobenius by q^d -power Frobenius fixes the factors with $f_i \mid d$, and can change the locus. Second, a unique local rank-one factor need not descend to a rational point over a number field. For example, $X^3 - 2$ is irreducible over $\mathbf{Q}$, whereas modulo 5 it factors as

$$(X - 3)(X^2 + 3X + 4),$$

with the quadratic factor irreducible and the two factors coprime. Its algebra over $\mathbf{Q}_5$ has one rank-one factor and one unramified quadratic factor, but $\text{Spec } \mathbf{Q}(\sqrt[3]{2})$ has no $\mathbf{Q}$ -rational point. In

the present application it is the already proved global decomposition $A_H = K_0 \times L$ that supplies descent. The local criterion alone is not a theorem giving regular Galois realizations.

3.6. Finite incidence and the unresolved geometric comparison. We retain the following finite identities because they identify the input that a proof independent of branch-cycle matching would have to transport. They do not construct relative correspondences on a semistable M_{23} -cover. Fix the natural degree-23 permutation representation $M_{23} \subset S_{23}$. Let $x \in 2A(M_{23})$, let $H_x = \text{Fix}(x)$, and let A_x be the set of its eight two-element sheet orbits. Thus H_x , with its natural incidence relation, is the seven-point Fano plane, and A_x is an affine torsor under $\mathbf{F}_2^3$. Put $B_x = H_x \amalg A_x$.

Lemma 3.15 (Fano–affine odd fixed-point lemma). *For every $c \in C_{M_{23}}(x)$,*

$$|\text{Fix}_{H_x}(c)| + |\text{Fix}_{A_x}(c)| \equiv 1 \pmod{2}.$$

Proof. Write $U = O_2(C_{M_{23}}(x))/\langle x \rangle \simeq \mathbf{F}_2^3$. The centralizer acts on H_x through $\text{GL}(U)$ acting on $U^* \setminus \{0\}$ and on A_x through $U: \text{GL}(U)$. Write the image of c as an affine map (t, g) . If $g - 1$ is singular, its dual fixes a nonzero space of dimension d , so it fixes $2^d - 1$ points of H_x , an odd number. The affine fixed-point equation has either no solution or an affine space parallel to $\ker(g - 1)$, hence an even number of solutions when nonempty. If $g - 1$ is invertible, the dual action fixes no point of H_x , while the affine equation has exactly one solution. Both cases give the assertion. $\square$

After a splitting extension and a common identification of the geometric sheets, let $D_y, D_z \simeq 23:11$ be the normalizers associated with the two marked wild branches. For $D = D_y$ or D_z , define

$$\mathcal{L}_D = \{(b, x^d, b^d) : b \in B_x, d \in D\}.$$

The action of D on x^D is free because a stabilizer order divides both 253 and $|C_{M_{23}}(x)| = 2688$. If $w \in x^{D_y} \cap x^{D_z}$, let $d_y(w)$ and $d_z(w)$ be the unique transporters carrying x to w . Then $c_w = d_y(w)d_z(w)^{-1} \in C_{M_{23}}(x)$. Equality of the basis elements indexed by b in the two incidence correspondences over w is equivalent to $b^{c_w} = b$. The preceding lemma gives

$$(1) \quad \deg(\mathcal{L}_{D_y} \cap \mathcal{L}_{D_z}) \bmod 2 = |x^{D_y} \cap x^{D_z}| \bmod 2 = \epsilon(\Theta).$$

Equivalently, after the splitting extension, regard B_x and each $\mathcal{L}_D$ as finite *étale* schemes. Take constant $\mathbf{F}_2$ -sheaves and use $\mathcal{L}_{D_y}$ and $\mathcal{L}_{D_z}$ as incidence correspondences in opposite directions. Their Lefschetz–Verdier pairing on the generic fibre is exactly the finite intersection in (1). Thus the generic construction specifies the schemes, sheaves, correspondences, and cohomological maps explicitly.

3.6.1. The local nearby-cycle calculation. Let R be a strictly henselian discrete valuation ring with residue field k and fraction field K , and let $p : E \rightarrow Q$ be a finite surjection. The finite Ferrand pushout [18]

$$\mathcal{P}_p = \text{Spec}(R^E) \amalg_{\text{Spec}(k^E)} \text{Spec}(k^Q)$$

has coordinate ring

$$A_p = R^E \times_{k^E} k^Q = \{(a_e) \in R^E : \bar{a}_e \text{ is constant on each fibre of } p\}.$$

For $q \in Q$, the strict local geometric generic fibre is the discrete set $E_q = p^{-1}(q)$. Therefore, with $\Lambda = \mathbf{F}_2$,

$$(2) \quad (R^0 \Psi \Lambda)_q = \Lambda[E_q], \quad (R^i \Psi \Lambda)_q = 0 \quad (i > 0).$$

Let $\alpha, \beta \in \Lambda^E$ select the two endpoint incidences. The generic cohomological maps are the identity on the selected normalization sections and zero on the others. Their generic pairing, and the pairing of their nearby-cycle specializations, are both

$$(3) \quad \sum_{e \in E_q} \alpha_e \beta_e.$$

Indeed, the specialized maps are

$$\Lambda \longrightarrow \Lambda[E_q], \quad 1 \longmapsto \sum_e \alpha_e [e], \quad \Lambda[E_q] \longrightarrow \Lambda, \quad [e] \longmapsto \beta_e.$$

This is the elementary finite-stalk instance of compatibility of the Lefschetz–Verdier pairing with nearby cycles in Lu–Zheng [23, Corollary 3.10].

There are also canonical maps

$$\Lambda \longrightarrow \Lambda[E_q] \longrightarrow \Lambda, \quad 1 \longmapsto \sum_e [e], \quad \sum_e a_e [e] \longmapsto \sum_e a_e.$$

Inserting these maps and then applying augmentation produces the fibre-sum product

$$(4) \quad \left(\sum_e \alpha_e \right) \left(\sum_e \beta_e \right).$$

This is a different correspondence, not the specialization of (3). For $E_q = \{1, 2\}$, $\alpha = (1, 0)$, and $\beta = (0, 1)$, the basiswise pairing is 0 while the product after augmentation is 1. Thus a conductor quotient cannot by itself justify replacing (3) by (4).

The normalization–conductor triangle does not alter this conclusion. After restriction to the generic fibre its conductor-supported terms vanish; nearby cycles recover the full permutation module in (2), not a rank-one quotient. Applying the counit $p_* \Lambda_E \rightarrow \Lambda_Q$ is an additional operation and must be incorporated into the relative correspondence if it is to be used.

3.6.2. What the integral multiplicities do and do not prove. Put $\mathcal{C} = 2A(M_{23})$, $T_D = x^D$, and $P_D = \mathcal{C} \setminus T_D$. At this stage these are finite subsets of a permutation group, not effective cycles on a constructed relative curve. For the natural sheet representation ρ , exact counting gives

$$\rho(\mathcal{C}) = 120J + 1035I, \quad \rho(T_D) = 8J + 69I, \quad \rho(P_D) = 112J + 966I.$$

In particular, a diagonal coefficient of the last matrix is 1078 and an off-diagonal coefficient is 112. Their divided difference is

$$(1078 - 112)/2 = 483 \equiv 1 \pmod{2}.$$

This is a calculation with specified integral representatives. The congruent representative $P_D - 2\mathcal{C}$ has image $-128J - 1104I \equiv 0 \pmod{4}$. Hence, in the unrestricted mapping cone of the graph-to-sheet map, the mod-2 class represented by P_D has a mod-4 lift and its coefficient Bockstein is zero.

For a binary vector of even weight, the function

$$Q(v) = \text{wt}(v)/2 \pmod{2}$$

satisfies

$$Q(v + w) = Q(v) + Q(w) + \langle v, w \rangle.$$

Indeed, the integer weight of $v + w$ is the sum of the two weights minus twice the size of the intersection of their supports. Each T_D has odd size 253, so Q is not defined on its indicator alone. Its value on the even-weight symmetric difference is obtained directly from $|T_{D_y} \triangle T_{D_z}| = 506 - 2|T_{D_y} \cap T_{D_z}|$. Together with $|P_D| = 3542$, this gives

$$Q(T_{D_y} + T_{D_z}) = 1 + \epsilon(\Theta), \quad Q(P_D) = 1.$$

These are finite quadratic identities. They do not by themselves give a quadratic refinement on nearby cycles.

In particular, the determinant of a perfect complex [20] is not automatically a symmetric line with degree equal to half its Euler characteristic. Assigning degree $m \bmod 2$ to the determinant of a rank- $2m$ module does not define a symmetric monoidal functor to ordinary graded lines: exchanging two rank-two blocks has determinant sign $+1$, whereas exchanging their proposed odd lines has Koszul sign -1 . Additional categorical structure and coherence data would be needed.

A geometric comparison would require a relative model, cohomological correspondences extending both finite incidences, and a construction retaining the two specified integral multiplicity vectors $\mathcal{C}$ and T_D . It would then have to prove, rather than assume, the identification of its generic invariant with $\epsilon(\Theta)$ and its special invariant with e_{sing} . Neither the finite pinching calculation above nor ordinary nearby-cycle duality [23] supplies these identifications. We do not assert such a relative construction or a second proof of theorem 1.2 here.

The next two sections record supporting arithmetic on the distinguished cover: first its explicit minimal projection, then the Fano and affine arithmetic of its branch fibre.

4. THE MINIMAL-DEGREE PROJECTION

This section makes the distinguished cover explicit in the smallest $\mathbf{Q}$ -defined source coordinate. Its role in the main argument is supporting rather than selective: the coordinate transports the Fano and affine residue data exactly, but it does not distinguish one point of the seven-cover Hurwitz scheme.

Set $D = T^2 + 23$. The coefficient of V^{23} in F is D^4 , so

$$\Phi := F, \quad \widehat{F} := D^{-4}F \in \mathbf{Q}(T)[V]$$

defines the same function field and is monic of degree 23 in V . We write C_0 for the affine plane curve $\Phi = 0$ and X for its normalization. The compactification under consideration is the closure in $\mathbf{P}_T^1 \times \mathbf{P}_V^1$.

4.1. The two points above $T^2 + 23 = 0$. Let $b, c \in X(\overline{\mathbf{Q}})$ be the unique points over the roots of D . They are conjugate over $\mathbf{Q}$ and each has ramification index 23 for the T -map [1, Section 3].

Lemma 4.1 (Valuations at the two ramification points). *At either $q \in \{b, c\}$ one has*

$$\text{ord}_q(T - T(q)) = 23, \quad \text{ord}_q(D) = 23, \quad \text{ord}_q(V) = -4,$$

and

$$\text{ord}_q\left(\frac{dT}{\Phi_V}\right) = 18.$$

Proof. The first two equalities follow from total ramification and the fact that D has a simple zero at $T(q)$. The coefficients of Φ , viewed as a polynomial in V , have a Newton-polygon edge joining $(0, 0)$ and $(23, 4)$ at $D = 0$. Hence its unique branch has $\text{ord}_q(V) = -4$.

For completeness, the terms of Φ_V on this branch have orders

$$23 \text{ord}_D(ia_i) - 4(i - 1),$$

where $a_i(T)$ is the coefficient of V^i . The minimum is 4, attained uniquely by differentiating the D^4V^{23} term; all other orders are at least 5. Thus $\text{ord}_q(\Phi_V) = 4$. Finally $\text{ord}_q(dT) = 23 - 1 = 22$, so $\text{ord}_q(dT/\Phi_V) = 22 - 4 = 18$. $\square$

The calculation is reproduced directly from the normalized coefficient table by `verification/verify_boundary_valuations.gp`.

For a polynomial $A(T, V)$ consider the adjoint differential

$$\omega_A = \frac{A(T, V) dT}{\Phi_V(T, V)}.$$

The interior of the bidegree- $(8, 23)$ rectangle gives the usual support $0 \leq i \leq 6, 0 \leq j \leq 21$ for monomials $T^i V^j$. Regularity at b and c sharpens this $7 \cdot 22 = 154$ -dimensional space substantially.

Lemma 4.2 (Adjoints regular at b and c). *The differentials ω_A having interior support and regular at both b and c are represented by the 88-dimensional space*

$$\begin{aligned} \mathcal{A} = & \bigoplus_{j=0}^4 V^j \mathbf{Q}[T]_{\leq 6} \oplus \bigoplus_{j=5}^{10} DV^j \mathbf{Q}[T]_{\leq 4} \\ & \oplus \bigoplus_{j=11}^{16} D^2 V^j \mathbf{Q}[T]_{\leq 2} \oplus \bigoplus_{j=17}^{21} D^3 V^j \mathbf{Q}. \end{aligned}$$

In particular,

$$\dim \mathcal{A} = 35 + 30 + 18 + 5 = 88.$$

Proof. Write $A = \sum_{j=0}^{21} a_j(T) V^j$. By lemma 4.1, a term $D^m c(T) V^j dT / \Phi_V$ has order

$$23m - 4j + 18$$

at b and c , unless c also vanishes there. Regularity therefore requires

$$m \geq \left\lceil \frac{4j - 18}{23} \right\rceil,$$

giving respectively $m = 0, 1, 2, 3$ on the four displayed blocks. Terms having distinct exponents j cannot cancel: their orders are distinct modulo 23. Divisibility by D^m lowers the residual T -degree from 6 to $6 - 2m$. Counting coefficients gives the stated dimension. $\square$

4.2. The affine nodes and the canonical system. At an ordinary node, Rosenlicht's adjoint condition [7] is the vanishing of the numerator A . Thus each node contributes one linear evaluation condition, and the rank computation below verifies independence. We impose the conditions in one stroke using the reduced singular scheme modulo 31.

Exact computation 4.3 (The node graph modulo 31). Over $\mathbf{F}_{31}$ the Jacobian ideal

$$(\Phi, \Phi_T, \Phi_V)$$

has lexicographic basis

$$h_{84}(T), \quad V - s(T),$$

where $\deg h_{84} = 84$ and h_{84} is squarefree. The determinant of the Hessian is a unit on this scheme. Thus the affine singular scheme consists geometrically of 84 reduced ordinary nodes.

This statement is certified by `verification/verify_nodes_mod31.sing`; the explicit h_{84} and s are in `data/node_graph_mod31.inc`. Evaluation of the basis in lemma 4.2 on the node graph gives an 84×88 matrix over $\mathbf{F}_{31}$.

Exact computation 4.4 (Canonical kernel and degree-4 pencil). The node-evaluation matrix has rank 84, so its kernel has dimension 4. This is the canonical adjoint space $H^0(X, K_X)$. On this kernel, vanishing at $b + c$ has rank 2, leaving the two-dimensional space $H^0(X, K_X - b - c)$ and hence a pencil.

Explanation of the two conditions at b and c . Among the blocks of lemma 4.2, the only term that can have order zero at b or c is

$$D^2(c_0 + c_1T + c_2T^2)V^{16}.$$

Its vanishing at both roots of D is equivalent to divisibility of the quadratic coefficient by D , namely

$$c_1 = 0, \quad c_0 = 23c_2.$$

These two conditions have rank 2 on the four-dimensional node kernel. The ranks are reproduced by `verification/verify_adjoint_mod31.py`. $\square$

The successive dimensions are therefore

$$154 \longrightarrow 88 \longrightarrow 4 \longrightarrow 2.$$

The last two arrows are certified by full-rank minors modulo 31. This good-reduction calculation is the modular construction step; it does not by itself certify the characteristic-zero equation. That role is played by the exact function-field identity and irreducibility proof in section 4.4.

If ω_0 and ω_1 form a basis of $H^0(X, K_X - b - c)$, then their ratio $W = \omega_0/\omega_1$ is a rational function on X . The resulting row-reduced-echelon-form normalized pencil was reconstructed over $\mathbf{Q}$ by the Chinese remainder theorem. The least common multiple of the reconstructed coefficient denominators is 91; clearing it gives $J_0, J_1 \in \mathbf{Z}[T, V]$. Their degrees in V are 20 and 21, respectively, and each has degree 6 in T .

4.3. Reconstruction of the bidegree (23, 4) equation. Set $W = J_0/J_1$. Eliminating V between $\Phi(T, V)$ and $J_0(T, V) - WJ_1(T, V)$ means extracting the desired factor from

$$\text{Res}_V(\Phi(T, V), J_0(T, V) - WJ_1(T, V)).$$

We performed this calculation modulo good primes in a stable row-reduced-echelon-form (RREF) normalization, reconstructed the coefficients, and then discarded the numerical evidence in favor of the exact certificate below.

For transparency, the equation used a 575-bit CRT modulus. All 120 coefficients reconstructed and reduced correctly at the independent holdout prime 500015017. The pencil used a 604-bit modulus and passed independent holdout prime 137. These holdouts are evidence about reconstruction, not ingredients in the proof of theorem 1.3; their complete records are `data/f4_crt_reconstruction.json` and `data/pencil_crt_reconstruction.json`. As an auxiliary geometric check, the reduction of P modulo 31 divides the displayed defining resultant; this is verified by `verification/verify_f4_mod31.sing`.

4.4. Exact certificate and the known degree minimum. Write

$$P(T, W) = \sum_{j=0}^{23} p_j(T)W^j.$$

Proposition 4.5 (Exact function-field identity). *In $\mathbf{Q}(T)[V]/(\Phi) = \mathbf{Q}(T)[V]/(\widehat{F})$ one has*

$$\sum_{j=0}^{23} p_j(T)J_0^j J_1^{23-j} = 0.$$

Equivalently, $P(T, J_0/J_1) = 0$ in $\mathbf{Q}(X)$.

Proof. This is a polynomial identity modulo $\Phi = F$, equivalently modulo the monic degree-23 relation $\widehat{F}$ over $\mathbf{Q}(T)$. The supplied Singular certificate evaluates the left side by homogeneous Horner reduction and obtains zero. The SageMath certificate independently rebuilds Φ, P, J_0, J_1 from JSON coefficient tables, reads no Singular inputs, and performs the same calculation in its own polynomial arithmetic. A self-contained Magma certificate repeats the quotient-ring identity from the same canonical tables. All computations are exact. $\square$

Proposition 4.6 (Irreducibility). *The polynomial P is primitive and irreducible in $\mathbf{Q}[T, W]$. In particular it is irreducible in $\mathbf{Q}(T)[W]$.*

Proof. The coefficient content is 1. Its reduction modulo 31 retains bidegree $(23, 4)$ and is irreducible in $\mathbf{F}_{31}[T, W]$, as checked independently by Singular, SageMath, and Magma. Gauss's lemma proves the claim. $\square$

Proof of Theorem 1.3. By proposition 4.5, $\mathbf{Q}(T, W)$ is a subfield of $\mathbf{Q}(T, V)$. By proposition 4.6,

$$[\mathbf{Q}(T, W) : \mathbf{Q}(T)] = 23.$$

The source equation also gives $[\mathbf{Q}(T, V) : \mathbf{Q}(T)] = 23$, hence the inclusion is an equality. The regular M_{23} monodromy follows from [1, Proposition 3.5 and Corollary 3.6].

Regard P as a polynomial in T over $\mathbf{Q}(W)$. Since P is irreducible and has positive T -degree, Gauss's lemma and $\deg_T P = 4$ give $[\mathbf{Q}(T, W) : \mathbf{Q}(W)] = 4$. Thus W has degree 4 on X . That this degree is minimal over $\mathbf{Q}$ is the nonsplit-quadric argument already given in [1, Remark 3.4]: every map of degree at most 3 on the geometric genus-4 curve comes from a ruling of its canonical quadric, but neither ruling is defined over $\mathbf{Q}$. Our calculation in proposition 5.21 identifies the quadratic ruling field explicitly. $\square$

5. ARITHMETIC OF THE DISTINGUISHED BRANCH FIBRE

The minimal equation and the original plane equation describe the same cover, but their coordinates need not display a singular branch fibre in the same way. We first transport the fibre over $T = 0$ exactly between the two models. We then determine its local monodromy, Fano-plane incidence, number fields, and Galois-selected flags, before asking how much of this internal arithmetic can explain the distinguished point of the seven-cover moduli problem.

5.1. Transport to the minimal-degree coordinate. The factors in the source coordinate are

$$\begin{aligned} H_7(V) &= V^7 - 312V^6 + 43848V^5 - 3914896V^4 + 241123008V^3 \\ &\quad - 9876755712V^2 + 251799776256V - 2694891036672, \\ R_8(V) &= V^8 + 156V^7 - 1290V^6 - 1217744V^5 - 40611765V^4 \\ &\quad + 2044635024V^3 + 115083889782V^2 + 968032514052V - 6058197515007. \end{aligned}$$

Both are irreducible over $\mathbf{Q}$. The corresponding primitive factors in the minimal-degree coordinate are

$$\begin{aligned} \tilde{H}_7(W) &= 52590311992108774196155W^7 - 8380256819525975478304W^6 \\ &\quad + 554571400016133612672W^5 - 19338639702208327424W^4 \\ &\quad + 367883711159073536W^3 - 3404298821468160W^2 \\ &\quad + 7203244769280W + 62710185984, \end{aligned}$$

and

$$\begin{aligned}\tilde{R}_8(W) = & 10551428180783458291047W^8 - 2504505235463133310560W^7 \\ & + 258988485843116269632W^6 - 15238022132962377728W^5 \\ & + 557642314807148032W^4 - 12985270524477440W^3 \\ & + 187639106142208W^2 - 1535652528128W + 5439225856.\end{aligned}$$

Proof of Theorem 1.4. Reconstruct F, P, J_0, J_1 from their canonical integer coefficient tables. Exact factorization over $\mathbf{Q}$ gives the two displayed identities and proves the irreducibility of all four factors. Euclidean reduction gives

$$\gcd(J_1(0, V), H_7 R_8) = 1,$$

so the specialized rational function is defined at every geometric point of the fibre.

Let v_7 be the image of V in $K_7 = \mathbf{Q}[V]/(H_7)$ and put

$$w_7 = J_0(0, v_7)/J_1(0, v_7).$$

Exact minimal-polynomial computation gives

$$\text{minpoly}_{\mathbf{Q}}(w_7) = \frac{\tilde{H}_7}{52590311992108774196155}.$$

In particular w_7 has degree 7 and generates K_7 . Substitution therefore defines the first displayed field isomorphism. The identical calculation in $K_8 = \mathbf{Q}[V]/(R_8)$ gives

$$\text{minpoly}_{\mathbf{Q}}\left(\frac{J_0(0, v_8)}{J_1(0, v_8)}\right) = \frac{\tilde{R}_8}{10551428180783458291047},$$

and proves the second isomorphism. Applying all embeddings into $\overline{\mathbf{Q}}$ shows that the maps on roots are Galois-equivariant and bijective. Every step is reproduced by the certificate described in section 8. $\square$

Remark 5.1. The factor degrees provide a consistency check. The theorem also requires regularity of the rational coordinate throughout the fibre and generation of the full residue fields. The coprimality and minimal-polynomial checks verify these two properties.

5.2. Local monodromy at the branch point $T = 0$.

5.2.1. *Group-theoretic notation.* Fix a copy of $M_{23} \subset \text{Sym}(23)$ and elements

$$x \in 2A, \quad y \in 23A, \quad xy \in 23A,$$

so that $(x, y, (xy)^{-1})$ is a generating triple with class tuple $(2A, 23A, 23B)$. Set

$$K = O_2(C_{M_{23}}(x)), \quad H = \text{Fix}(x) \subset \{1, \dots, 23\}.$$

Since x has cycle shape $1^7 2^8$, $|H| = 7$; the fixed letters form a heptad in the Witt design $S(4, 7, 23)$. One has

$$C_{M_{23}}(x) \cong 2^4 : \text{PSL}_3(2), \quad |C_{M_{23}}(x)| = 2688, \quad |K| = 16.$$

For reproducibility, the certificate labeling uses

$$\begin{aligned}x &= (3\ 21)(4\ 16)(9\ 22)(10\ 15)(11\ 20)(12\ 19)(13\ 18)(14\ 17), \\ y &= (1\ 2\ 11\ 10\ 16\ 9\ 6\ 3\ 23\ 19\ 20\ 14\ 21\ 17\ 4\ 8\ 22\ 5\ 18\ 15\ 13\ 7\ 12), \\ r &= (3\ 18)(4\ 16)(5\ 6)(7\ 23)(10\ 14)(12\ 19)(13\ 21)(15\ 17).\end{aligned}$$

The involution r will compare the displayed triple with its complex conjugate in theorem 5.19. These representatives generate the same Nielsen class as the tuple given in [1, Section 3]; all assertions below are invariant under simultaneous conjugation.

For fixed y let

$$X_y = \{x' \in 2A : x'y \in 23A\}, \quad |X_y| = 161 = 7 \cdot 23,$$

whose $\langle y \rangle$ -translation orbits are the seven Nielsen classes. We call the class containing x the *distinguished class*; it is Nielsen class 6 in the enumeration used below. This is an internal label for the class specified by the displayed permutation x . The exact Hurwitz algebra calculation in section 3 later identifies it intrinsically as the unique degree-one component over K_0 .

Put $K_0 = \mathbf{Q}(\sqrt{-23})$. Let $\mathcal{H}_{\text{in}}$ denote the reduced zero-dimensional inner Hurwitz scheme over K_0 for normalized three-point covers with branch-cycle classes $(2A, 23A, 23B)$. Here *inner* means that generating triples are taken modulo simultaneous conjugation by M_{23} ; we use the standard Hurwitz-space and Nielsen-class formalism of [6]. Its seven geometric points correspond to the seven $\langle y \rangle$ -orbits above. In section 3 we compute a finite K_0 -scheme from exact equations and then identify it with $\mathcal{H}_{\text{in}}$ by certified branch cycles.

5.2.2. Branch points and the fibre over $T = 0$. The cover is branched over 0 and the two roots of $T^2 + 23$, with local monodromy $(2A, 23A, 23B)$ and total ramification at the order-23 points [1, Section 3]. The valuations and ordinary nodes were computed in lemma 4.1 and Exact computation 4.3. The discriminant separates the branch fibres from the projection singularities.

Proposition 5.2. *The integral model $F \in \mathbf{Z}[T, V]$ satisfies*

$$\text{Res}_V(F, F_V) = uT^8(T^2 + 23)^{92}G(T)^2, \quad \text{disc}_V(F) = -uT^8(T^2 + 23)^{88}G(T)^2, \quad \deg G = 84,$$

for some $u \in \mathbf{Q}^\times$, where G is squarefree and divides $\gcd(\text{Res}_V(F, F_V), \text{Res}_V(F, F_T))$, while T does not. Consequently:

- (1) the fibre over $T = 0$ consists of smooth points of the plane model, and $F(0, V) = 23^4 H_7 R_8^2$ gives cycle type $1^7 2^8$, the shape of $2A$;
- (2) the zeros of G account for projection singularities rather than branch points of the normalization; their good reduction modulo 31 is the 84-node scheme of Exact computation 4.3;
- (3) at $T^2 + 23$ the Newton polygon is a single segment of slope $4/23$, so the local extension is totally ramified of degree 23.

Riemann–Hurwitz gives

$$2g - 2 = -46 + 8 + 22 + 22 = 6, \quad g = 4.$$

For comparison, direct factorization for the minimal-degree equation gives, up to a nonzero rational constant,

$$\text{disc}_W P = T^8(T^2 + 23)^{22}H_{62}(T)^2, \quad \deg H_{62} = 62.$$

The factor T^8 records genuine ramification in both models. The residual square factors and the exponent at $T^2 + 23$ depend on the projection.

5.2.3. Why the cyclotomic obstruction vanishes.

Proposition 5.3. *y^λ is conjugate to y in M_{23} if and only if λ is a quadratic residue modulo 23; for the eleven nonsquares it lies in the opposite class $23B$.*

The two order-23 branch points are conjugate over $\mathbf{Q}$ and individually rational over $\mathbf{Q}(\sqrt{-23})$; the quadratic subfield of $\mathbf{Q}(\zeta_{23})$ fixed by the squares. Thus the branch swap matches the nonsquare part of the cyclotomic character. Fried’s branch-cycle argument sends (C_1, C_2, C_3) under σ to $(C_1^\lambda, C_2^\lambda, C_3^\lambda)$, with $\lambda = \chi(\sigma)$. For nonsquare λ the tuple becomes $(2A, 23B, 23A)$ while the same σ exchanges the two nonrational branch points. The classical obstruction therefore vanishes, but this permits field of moduli $\mathbf{Q}$ without forcing the fixed point of [1].

5.3. The Fano plane on the seven unramified points. The factors H_7 and R_8 were displayed in section 5.1. Their roots are respectively the seven unramified points and eight ramification points above $T = 0$.

Theorem 5.4. *$\text{Gal}(H_7) \cong \text{PSL}_3(2)$, acting on the seven unramified sheets. The 21 involutions each fix exactly three sheets. There are seven distinct fixed triples, each arising from three involutions, and these triples form a $2-(7, 3, 1)$ design. Thus the sheets are the points of a Fano plane and the fixed triples are its lines.*

A *flag* means an incident point–line pair in this plane.

Proposition 5.5. *Let $\alpha_1, \dots, \alpha_7$ be the roots of H_7 . The three-subset-sum resolvent*

$$\mathcal{R}_3(Y) = \prod_{1 \leq i < j < k \leq 7} (Y - (\alpha_i + \alpha_j + \alpha_k))$$

factors over $\mathbf{Q}$ into irreducible factors of degrees 7 and 28. The degree-seven factor is

$$\begin{aligned} L_7(Y) = & Y^7 - 936Y^6 + 379728Y^5 - 86588640Y^4 + 11922182400Y^3 \\ & - 982633068288Y^2 + 44572755885824Y - 859311381083136. \end{aligned}$$

Its roots are the sums along the seven Fano lines. The fields $\mathbf{Q}[V]/(H_7)$ and $\mathbf{Q}[Y]/(L_7)$ are nonisomorphic, but they have the same Galois closure and Dedekind zeta function. Their common field discriminant is

$$2^4 3^6 23^6 = 1726690609296.$$

Their point and line stabilizers are nonconjugate subgroups of order 24 with equal permutation characters, the classical Gassmann pair for $\text{PSL}_3(2)$; the resulting equality of Dedekind zeta functions is the Gassmann–Perlis criterion [8].

Corollary 5.6. *The roots of $\tilde{H}_7$ carry the transported Fano-plane point structure. Its line field is defined by L_7 , and the point and line fields remain nonisomorphic arithmetically equivalent septics.*

Proof. The first isomorphism of theorem 1.4 identifies the two seven-element Galois sets. Fixed triples and incidence are functorial under this identification. $\square$

Proposition 5.7. *The points, lines, and flags admit the following description through $C_{M_{23}}(x)$. All 99 involutions of $C_{M_{23}}(x)$ belong to class 2A, and:*

- (1) *the fifteen nonidentity elements of K fix H pointwise. The central element x is one conjugacy class and the other fourteen form a second. Writing $U = K/\langle x \rangle \cong \mathbf{F}_2^3$, the nonzero elements of U identify with the seven lines; the plane is $\mathbf{P}(U^*)$ on points and $\mathbf{P}(U)$ on lines;*
- (2) *as an $\mathbf{F}_2[C_{M_{23}}(x)]$ -module, K is indecomposable, with unique minimal nonzero submodule $\langle x \rangle$. Each nonzero element of U has two preimages in K , exchanged by multiplication by x ;*
- (3) *the 84 involutions of $C_{M_{23}}(x) \setminus K$ form one class and act on H as transvections. The map to center and fixed line is a surjection onto the 21 flags, with four involutions above each flag. For such t ,*

$$C_K(t) = \langle x \rangle \cup \{\text{the two lifts of the axis}\}, \quad \text{Fix}(t) \cap H = \text{axis}(t).$$

There is no $C_{M_{23}}(x)$ -invariant complement to $\langle x \rangle$ in K . Moreover the outer point–line duality of $\mathrm{PSL}_3(2)$ is not induced by an automorphism of $C_{M_{23}}(x)$ or by a permutation of the 23 sheets normalizing $C_{M_{23}}(x)$:

$$\mathrm{Aut}(C_{M_{23}}(x)) = \mathrm{Inn}(C_{M_{23}}(x)) \quad (\text{order } 1344), \quad N_{\mathrm{Sym}(23)}(C_{M_{23}}(x)) = C_{M_{23}}(x).$$

Thus no such symmetry exchanges the point and line Galois sets.

5.4. Number fields obtained from the fibre. Put

$$E = \mathrm{Spl}_{\mathbf{Q}}(H_7), \quad L_0 = \mathrm{Spl}_{\mathbf{Q}}(H_7 R_8).$$

We construct a third field M and obtain

$$\mathbf{Q} \subset E \subset L_0 \subset M, \quad [E : \mathbf{Q}] = 168, \quad [L_0 : E] = 8, \quad [M : L_0] = 2.$$

The successive groups over $\mathbf{Q}$ are $\mathrm{PSL}_3(2)$, $2^3 : \mathrm{PSL}_3(2)$, and $2^4 : \mathrm{PSL}_3(2)$. The corresponding permutation actions are, respectively, those on the seven unramified points, on the eight ramification points, and on the two local branches at each ramification point.

5.4.1. The splitting field of $H_7 R_8$. The local decomposition group centralizes x . Since x exchanges the two local branches at a ramification point but fixes its root of R_8 , the action on the eight roots factors through $C_{M_{23}}(x)/\langle x \rangle$. The translation subgroup is $U = K/\langle x \rangle \cong \mathbf{F}_2^3$. After choosing an affine origin, the difference of two roots is a nonzero vector of U , hence a Fano line by proposition 5.7; each of the seven nonzero differences occurs for four of the 28 unordered pairs.

Theorem 5.8. *The splitting field of $H_7 R_8$ has Galois group $2^3 : \mathrm{PSL}_3(2)$ of order 1344, acting affinely on the eight roots of R_8 . The restriction $\mathrm{Gal}(L_0/\mathbf{Q}) \rightarrow \mathrm{Gal}(E/\mathbf{Q})$ has kernel $K/\langle x \rangle \cong (\mathbf{Z}/2)^3$.*

Proof. Decomposition theory at the tame rational place, together with equality of arithmetic and geometric monodromy [1], embeds $\mathrm{Gal}(L_0/\mathbf{Q})$ in $C_{M_{23}}(x)/\langle x \rangle$. Restriction to E is surjective, and its kernel is a submodule of the irreducible three-dimensional module U , hence either trivial or all of U . At $p = 599$, H_7 and L_7 split completely while R_8 factors into four quadratics. Frobenius is therefore trivial on E but a nonzero translation on the roots of R_8 , proving that the kernel is U . $\square$

Independently, a direct number-field computation gives $[\mathrm{Spl}_{\mathbf{Q}}(R_8) : \mathbf{Q}] = 1344$.

5.4.2. Affine frames and specialization. Let A be the eight roots of R_8 . An ordered affine frame is a tuple (a_0, a_1, a_2, a_3) whose three differences $a_i - a_0$ form a basis of U . Let

$$\mathcal{F}(A) = \{\text{ordered affine frames of } A\}/U.$$

Proposition 5.9. *$\mathcal{F}(A)$ has 168 elements. The action of $C_{M_{23}}(x)/\langle x \rangle$ descends to a free transitive action of $C_{M_{23}}(x)/K \cong \mathrm{PSL}_3(2)$. Via proposition 5.7, a translation class of frames is equivalently an ordered basis of the Fano line module.*

Proof. There are $8 \cdot 7 \cdot 6 \cdot 4 = 1344$ affine frames. Translation acts freely on the eight origins, leaving 168. The quotient $\mathrm{PSL}_3(2) = \mathrm{GL}_3(2)$ acts freely and transitively on ordered bases of U . $\square$

Let S be the marked geometric generic fibre, based at the tangential basepoint $T \rightarrow 0$. For $\sigma \in \mathfrak{S}_{\mathbf{Q}}$, let $d(\sigma)$ be its descent permutation. Since the inertia x has order two, the branch-cycle lemma places $d(\sigma)$ in $C_{M_{23}}(x)$. Write $\rho_8 : \mathfrak{S}_{\mathbf{Q}} \rightarrow \mathrm{Sym}(A)$ for the Galois action on the roots of R_8 .

Proposition 5.10 (Tame specialization at $T = 0$). *For every $\sigma \in \mathfrak{S}_{\mathbf{Q}}$,*

$$\rho_8(\sigma) = \text{pair}(d(\sigma)),$$

where *pair* is the induced action on the eight two-sheet inertia orbits. Consequently the induced action on $\mathcal{F}(A)$ is the one obtained from the generic-fibre descent permutation.

Proof. Let $R = \mathbf{Q}[T]_{(T)}^h$ and normalize $\text{Spec } R$ in the cover. At a geometric point of ramification index e , tameness and smoothness give the completed local form $T = u^e$ after extracting an e th root of a unit. The e sheets form one inertia orbit and specialize to one point. Hence specialization gives a canonical Galois-equivariant bijection

$$S/\langle x \rangle \xrightarrow{\sim} \{\text{geometric points above } T = 0\}.$$

Restricting to the eight two-element orbits proves the formula. This is the finite-set case of tame specialization [24, Exposé XIII, Section 2.10]. $\square$

5.4.3. *Separating the two branches.* The group $C_{M_{23}}(x)$ is perfect, its center is $\langle x \rangle$, and the central extension

$$1 \longrightarrow \langle x \rangle \longrightarrow C_{M_{23}}(x) \longrightarrow C_{M_{23}}(x)/\langle x \rangle \longrightarrow 1$$

does not split. It acts faithfully and transitively on the sixteen local branches above the eight roots of R_8 , with branch stabilizer isomorphic to $\text{PSL}_3(2)$.

Near a root v of R_8 , the two branches have expansions

$$V = v \pm \sqrt{e(v)T} + O(T), \quad e(v) = -\frac{2F_T(0, v)}{F_{VV}(0, v)}.$$

Since $F_{VV}(0, v) = 2 \cdot 23^4 H_7(v) R'_8(v)^2$, the square class of $e(v)$ is represented by

$$c(V) \equiv -F_T(0, V) H_7(V) \pmod{R_8}.$$

Theorem 5.11. *The eight values $c(v)$ represent one nontrivial square class in $L_0^\times/L_0^{\times 2}$. If $M = L_0(\sqrt{c(v)})$ for any root v , then*

$$\text{Gal}(M/\mathbf{Q}) \cong C_{M_{23}}(x) = 2^4 : \text{PSL}_3(2), \quad [M : L_0] = 2,$$

and the nontrivial element of $\text{Gal}(M/L_0)$ is x .

Proof. Tame local theory identifies the splitting field over $\mathbf{Q}((T))$ as $\mathcal{L} = L_0((\sqrt{cT}))$, with Galois group $C_{M_{23}}(x)$. Since $C_{M_{23}}(x)$ is perfect, $\sqrt{T} \notin \mathcal{L}$ and c is not a square in L_0 . After adjoining $\sqrt{T}$ the Galois group is $C_{M_{23}}(x) \times \mathbf{Z}/2$. The diagonal involution $(x, -1)$ fixes $\sqrt{c} = \sqrt{cT}/\sqrt{T}$, so taking constant fields gives

$$\text{Gal}(M/\mathbf{Q}) \cong (C_{M_{23}}(x) \times \mathbf{Z}/2)/\langle (x, -1) \rangle \cong C_{M_{23}}(x).$$

Exact arithmetic checks additionally show that $X^2 - dc(V)$ is irreducible over $\mathbf{Q}[V]/(R_8)$ for

$$d \in \{\pm 1, \pm 2, \pm 3, \pm 6, \pm 23, \pm 46, \pm 69, \pm 138\}.$$

At each of fourteen primes below $3 \cdot 10^5$ splitting completely in L_0 , the eight values have one quadratic character; at six, beginning with 13049, it is -1 , independently certifying nonsquareness. $\square$

The polynomial R_8 has four real roots. Exactly two have $c(v) > 0$, so both local branches above them are real; the other two have $c(v) < 0$, so their branches are exchanged by complex conjugation. This agrees with the permutation r , which fixes the branches above two real ramification points and exchanges the branches above the other two.

Corollary 5.12. *Replacing (H_7, R_8) by $(\tilde{H}_7, \tilde{R}_8)$ leaves the fields E, L_0, M , the affine torsor, and the centralizer action unchanged under the transport induced by $W = J_0/J_1$.*

Proof. Theorem 1.4 identifies both residue Galois sets. The first two splitting fields and their functorial actions agree. The final quadratic extension belongs to the normalized cover and separates its local branches, independently of the coordinate labeling the residue points. $\square$

5.4.4. Ramification.

Theorem 5.13. *Let $E_8 = \mathbf{Q}[V]/(R_8)$ and $E'_8 = E_8(\sqrt{c(v)})$. The fields $\mathbf{Q}[V]/(H_7)$, $\mathbf{Q}[Y]/(L_7)$, and E_8 have discriminants $2^4 3^6 23^6$, $2^4 3^6 23^6$, and $2^{16} 3^6 23^6$. The relative discriminant of E'_8/E_8 has norm $2^8 3^2 23^2$. In particular, M is unramified outside $\{2, 3, 23\}$. The complete lists of pairs (e, f) in the constituent fields are*

p	either septic field	E_8
23	(7, 1)	(1, 1), (7, 1)
3	(1, 1), (3, 1), (3, 1)	(1, 1), (1, 1), (3, 1), (3, 1)
2	(1, 1), (3, 1), (3, 1)	(4, 2).

Thus the ramified septic primes at 2 are tame; the ramified primes at 3 and the octic prime at 2 are wild. At 23, inertia and decomposition in $L_0/\mathbf{Q}$ are C_7 and 7:3, respectively; in $M/\mathbf{Q}$ they are C_{14} and $C_2 \times (7:3)$.

Proof. The discriminants and prime decompositions are computed from exact maximal orders. Since M is the normal closure obtained by adjoining the conjugates of the local square root defining E'_8/E_8 , their discriminant support gives the asserted bound for M .

At 23 the constituent extensions are tame. The Galois closure is therefore tame, with cyclic inertia acting on the octic roots as one 7-cycle and one fixed point; its inertia is C_7 . The normalizer of this subgroup in $2^3:\mathrm{PSL}_3(2)$ is 7:3. Tame local theory gives $\phi\tau\phi^{-1} = \tau^{23} = \tau^2$; the exponent 2 has order three modulo 7, so the decomposition group is the full 7:3.

The relative discriminant of E'_8/E_8 has exponent one at each of the two primes above 23. Those quadratic extensions are ramified. The ramification index of L_0/E_8 at either chosen prolongation is either 7 or 1, hence odd, so the quadratic ramification persists. Thus inertia in M has order 14 and is cyclic by tameness. The decomposition group is a central extension of 7:3 by C_2 . Since 21 is odd this extension splits, giving $C_2 \times (7:3)$. $\square$

The relative discriminant proves ramification of E'_8/E_8 at 2 and 3, but does not by itself prove its persistence after base change to L_0 . We make no assertion here about the full inertia groups in M at those two primes. In particular, a census restricted to order-12 subgroups cannot establish that the actual inertia at 2 has order 12.

5.5. Flags selected by complex conjugation and Frobenius.

Theorem 5.14. *Every involution of $\mathrm{PSL}_3(2)$ acts as a transvection. It fixes one line pointwise, its axis, and has a distinguished center on that line. The map from involutions to center–axis pairs is a bijection onto the 21 flags.*

On points the cycle type is $1^3 2^2$. Besides the axis, exactly two lines are invariant, each consisting of the center and one transposed pair. The group is transitive on flags; both a flag stabilizer and an involution centralizer have order 8.

The field E has no real embeddings and 84 conjugate pairs of complex embeddings. Each complex place determines the flag of its conjugation involution, giving a four-to-one map from the 84 places to the 21 flags. The same construction applies at an unramified finite place whose Frobenius is an involution.

Corollary 5.15. *For complex conjugation, the axis is the set of three real roots of H_7 . Their sum is a root of L_7 . The center is the unique real root lying on the other two invariant lines; numerically it is the largest real root, approximately 102.2684.*

If p is unramified and H_7 has factorization type $1^3 2^2$ modulo p , then Frobenius is an involution. Such primes have Chebotarev density $1/8$.

Theorem 5.16. *Let N_{28} be the degree-28 nonlinear factor of $\mathcal{R}_3$, and exclude primes dividing $\text{Res}(L_7, N_{28})$. At every remaining unramified prime where H_7 has type $1^3 2^2$, the three roots in $\mathbf{F}_p$ sum to a root of L_7 and form the axis. The other four roots form two conjugate pairs. Counting, for each fixed root, how many pairs complete a Fano line gives $(0, 0, 2)$; the root with count 2 is the center. Exact computation checks all 9,889 such primes below 10^6 . Below that bound the only excluded collision is $p = 22159$.*

The real axis is defined over $\mathbb{R}$ but not over $\mathbf{Q}$, since $\text{Gal}(E/\mathbf{Q})$ is transitive on the seven lines. At 23 one sees the complementary Singer-cycle picture: after cyclically labeling the seven points, one Fano line is a difference set and the other six are its translates.

5.6. A first obstruction: geometric reflection. The branch divisor is preserved by the rational base involution

$$\tau : \mathbf{P}_T^1 \longrightarrow \mathbf{P}_T^1, \quad T \longmapsto -T,$$

which fixes the 2A branch point and exchanges the two order-23 branch points. It does not, however, lift to any of the seven covers. The two endpoint inertia generators lie in the distinct classes 23A and 23B. A holomorphic branch swap preserves the orientation of a small loop and therefore preserves its inertia conjugacy class; inversion occurs only for an orientation-reversing comparison such as complex conjugation.

Proposition 5.17 (Geometric reflection obstruction). *The holomorphic involution $\tau : T \mapsto -T$ has no lift to a cover in the Nielsen class $(2A, 23A, 23B)$. In contrast, the orientation-reversing comparison equations*

$$r \in C_{M_{23}}(x), \quad y^r = z^{-1}, \quad z^r = y^{-1}$$

have solution counts $(0, 0, 1, 0, 0, 1, 1)$ on the seven normalized triples. Thus IDs 3, 6, 7 are the classes fixed by the chosen complex-conjugation action.

Proof. For the natural degree-23 action, exact computation gives

$$C_{S_{23}}(M_{23}) = 1, \quad N_{S_{23}}(M_{23}) = M_{23}.$$

For every normalized triple, y is not conjugate to z in M_{23} , whereas it is conjugate to z^{-1} . Any sheet permutation induced by a holomorphic lift would normalize M_{23} and carry a positive local inertia generator to a conjugate positive generator at the other endpoint. The normalizer identity would place it in M_{23} , contradicting the first class calculation. Complex conjugation reverses the local loop, so its finite comparison uses z^{-1} instead. Exhausting the displayed orientation-reversing equations gives the asserted counts. $\square$

Let

$$Y_x = \{y'' \in 23A : xy'' \in 23A\}.$$

Pairs (x, y'') represent the seven Nielsen classes, and $C_{M_{23}}(x)$ acts on Y_x by conjugation.

Proposition 5.18. *The group M_{23} acts freely on the admissible pairs (x', y') with $x' \in 2A$, $y' \in 23A$, and $x'y' \in 23A$. Moreover*

$$|Y_x| = 18816 = 7 \cdot 2688,$$

and Y_x is the disjoint union of seven free $C_{M_{23}}(x)$ -orbits, one per Nielsen class. Equivalently,

$$|Y_x| = |X_y| \frac{|23A|}{|2A|} = 161 \cdot \frac{443520}{3795} = 18816.$$

In these coordinates complex conjugation is

$$\mu : Y_x \longrightarrow Y_x, \quad \mu(y'') = xy''.$$

Theorem 5.19. *The equation*

$$y''^w = xy'', \quad w \in C_{M_{23}}(x),$$

has a solution exactly when the corresponding Nielsen class is fixed by complex conjugation. Exactly three classes are fixed. For each, the comparison element w is unique, lies in $C_{M_{23}}(x) \setminus K$, and acts as a transvection on the roots of H_7 . For the distinguished class, the unique solution is $w = r$; it satisfies $x^r = x$ and $y^r = xy$. Its center and axis give the real flag of theorem 5.14.

At the chosen real place, complex conjugation exchanges the same two branch points and induces this orientation-reversing permutation on the Nielsen set. The element r acts on the roots of H_7 with type $1^3 2^2$, fixes three Fano lines, and fixes four roots of R_8 . Correspondingly, H_7, L_7, R_8 have 3, 3, 4 real roots. The three fixed classes are the fixed set of this one complex-conjugation element. A $\mathbf{Q}$ -defined cubic subscheme would require stability under the full absolute Galois group. The calculation neither establishes such stability nor explains why the distinguished class is globally fixed.

To relate the fibre arithmetic to the fixed-class problem, we now separate what is supplied by the unpointed branch-fibre structures from the additional relative geometric data that a specialization proof would require.

5.7. Why unpointed branch-fibre data do not distinguish the fixed point. The construction of [1] starts from a seven-element Nielsen class. Its Galois-fixed point produces the rational cover studied here. The Fano plane is attached instead to the seven unramified points in the chosen $2A$ branch fibre of that cover. Thus the results above start from the known rational cover and describe arithmetic internal to it; its descent is an input from [1].

The roles of the structures above may be summarized as follows.

- (1) The minimal function W transports the residue fields between the two plane models, while the Fano incidence is intrinsic to the chosen fibre.
- (2) The Fano plane is intrinsic to the seven fixed sheets of the chosen $2A$ fibre, but no individual Fano line is Galois invariant over $\mathbf{Q}$.
- (3) The affine-frame torsor is compatible with tame specialization from the geometric generic fibre to the fibre over $T = 0$. Distinguishing the rational Nielsen class from the other six requires additional pointed descent data.

The coordinate comparison preserves all Fano and affine residue data, so the finite incidence calculations of §3.6 are unchanged by passing to the minimal-degree model. The branch fibre by itself still does not distinguish the degree-one Hurwitz point. A compatible construction over the local Hurwitz model, retaining the specified integral multiplicities, is not supplied by this coordinate change.

There is also an exact, entirely group-theoretic limit on what unpointed characteristic-23 inertia can determine. Let $I \leq M_{23}$ have order 23 and put $D = N_{M_{23}}(I)$. Direct computation in the supplied permutation model gives $D \cong 23:11$. The conjugates of the unpointed inertia subgroup I are therefore indexed by the 40320 points of M_{23}/D . Once a chosen local object is reduced to its unpointed order-23 inertia subgroup, its possible placements are exactly the points of this homogeneous space.

Proposition 5.20 (Unpointed 23-inertia obstruction). *For each of the three complex-conjugation-fixed Nielsen classes, let r be the orientation-reversing comparison of proposition 5.17 and let*

$$A = C_{M_{23}}(x) \cap C_{M_{23}}(r).$$

Then $|A| = 32$, the three ordered pairs (x, r) are simultaneously conjugate in M_{23} , and A acts freely on the 40320 conjugates of I , indexed by M_{23}/D . The involution r divides them into 20160 unordered pairs, on which $A/\langle r \rangle$ acts freely. Consequently there are 1260 orbits of reflection-pairs under $A/\langle r \rangle$ for each fixed Nielsen class. In particular, unpointed order-23 inertia together with (x, r) does not canonically select one pair or distinguish the distinguished class from the other two complex-conjugation-fixed classes.

Proof. Exact computation gives $|A| = 32$ and one simultaneous-conjugacy orbit for the three anchors. Since $|D| = 253$ is odd, the stabilizer in the 2-group A of any coset in M_{23}/D is an intersection with a conjugate of D and is therefore trivial. Thus A acts freely. The element r is central in A and has no fixed coset. An element of A stabilizing one of its unordered two-element orbits either fixes a coset, hence is the identity, or sends it to its r -translate, hence is r . The induced $A/\langle r \rangle$ -action is free, and

$$\frac{20160}{|A|/2} = \frac{20160}{16} = 1260.$$

□

Thus a 23-adic argument must augment the two inertia subgroups with local–global comparison data. More precisely, the characteristic-23 Kummer coordinate has two C_{11} -orbits on its nonzero parameters: the squares in $\mathbf{F}_{23}^\times$ and their nonsquare coset. On the Fano side, if $F_{\mathbb{F}} = E^{D_8}$ is a flag field, the two Klein four subgroups $V_4 \subset D_8$ give two quadratic extensions $E^{V_4}/F_{\mathbb{F}}$. A proposed explanation along these lines would need a Galois-equivariant comparison between these two explicitly defined two-element structures.

There is another natural quadratic datum on the curve, but it does not supply this comparison. Let (A_0, A_1, A_2, A_3) be the RREF-normalized basis of the canonical adjoint space reconstructed from the same 88 coefficient positions used above. Order quadratic monomials as

$$X_0^2, X_0X_1, X_0X_2, X_0X_3, X_1^2, X_1X_2, X_1X_3, X_2^2, X_2X_3, X_3^2.$$

The nonsquare discriminant of this canonical quadric is the obstruction used in [1, Remark 3.4] to prove that degree 4 is minimal over $\mathbf{Q}$. The next proposition refines that argument by identifying the ruling field exactly; that field is also relevant to the local–global comparison pursued here.

Proposition 5.21 (Canonical ruling field). *The unique quadric containing the canonical image, normalized to have coefficient 1 at X_3^2 , has coefficient vector*

$$\frac{1}{297} \begin{pmatrix} 442260599149123, -18897532752913, -34200754149, 794833324, \\ 168493762065, 745707549, -14145827, 660893, -31345, 297 \end{pmatrix}.$$

If B is twice its symmetric Gram matrix, then

$$\det B = \frac{644454138716416151027888}{970299} = 4873 \left(\frac{38141181796}{3267} \right)^2, \quad 4873 = 11 \cdot 443.$$

Consequently the two rulings are governed by

$$\mathbf{Q}(\sqrt{4873}),$$

which is different from $K_0 = \mathbf{Q}(\sqrt{-23})$, the field over which the two order-23 branch points are ordered.

Proof. The four canonical RREF vectors are reconstructed over $\mathbf{Q}$ from 39 good primes with a 604-bit CRT modulus; the ten quadric coefficients use a 141-bit modulus. Both reconstructions agree coefficient by coefficient at the independent holdout prime 137, and the canonical basis

reduces to the directly recomputed basis modulo 31. Exact reduction in $\mathbf{Q}(T)[V]/(\widehat{F})$ annihilates the displayed quadratic combination of the ten products $A_i A_j$; their coefficient matrix has rank 9, proving uniqueness. Exact determinant evaluation gives the displayed square class. The components of the Fano scheme of lines on a smooth quadric surface are defined over its discriminant extension, so the ruling field is $\mathbf{Q}(\sqrt{4873})$. The SageMath and Magma certificates independently repeat the quotient-ring, rank, and determinant calculations. $\square$

The quadratic extension governing the two rulings cannot supply this comparison. Indeed, retain the notation $F_{\mathfrak{H}} = E^{D_8}$ and let $E^{V_4}/F_{\mathfrak{H}}$ be either of the two quadratic flag extensions just defined. If its square class were the product of the square classes obtained from $K_0/\mathbf{Q}$ and from the ruling extension $\mathbf{Q}(\sqrt{4873})/\mathbf{Q}$, then

$$E^{V_4} = F_{\mathfrak{H}} \mathbf{Q}(\sqrt{-23 \cdot 4873}).$$

The right side would imply $\mathbf{Q}(\sqrt{-23 \cdot 4873}) \subset E$. This is impossible because $\text{Gal}(E/\mathbf{Q}) \cong \text{PSL}_3(2)$ has no quotient of order two. Thus the ruling field does not provide the required local–global comparison.

The reflection, inertia, and ruling-field calculations determine the reach and the limits of the arithmetic internal to the distinguished cover. They do not by themselves construct the degree-one component of the seven-cover moduli problem. The local criterion of section 3.5 uses the normalized integral Hurwitz algebra; it is not a consequence of these unpointed branch-fibre data.

We now leave the branch fibre for an independent global application of the minimal equation.

6. ARITHMETIC SPECIALIZATIONS

At $T = 0$ the specialized polynomial is necessarily reducible and non-squarefree: it records the decomposition and inertia groups at a branch point, not the generic monodromy. Away from the branch locus the same degree-23 equation returns to the full Mathieu group.

We first record the specialization fact that identifies the ambient group.

Lemma 6.1 (Specialization subgroup). *Let $Q(T, x) \in \mathbf{Q}[T, x]$ have splitting field $L/\mathbf{Q}(T)$ with Galois group G . If the leading coefficient and discriminant in x are nonzero at $t \in \mathbf{Q}$, then the splitting field of $Q(t, x)$ has Galois group isomorphic, in its action on the roots, to a subgroup of G .*

Proof. Work over $R = \mathbf{Q}[T]_{(T-t)}$. After dividing by its unit leading coefficient, Q is monic with unit discriminant. The normalization in L is unramified above $T = t$. The residue extension at a chosen prime has Galois group its decomposition group, a subgroup of G . The distinct specialized roots generate that residue extension, proving the claim. $\square$

For an integer $t \equiv 2 \pmod{319}$, let c_t be the positive gcd of the coefficients of $P(t, x)$ and set

$$f_t(x) = c_t^{-1} P(t, x) \in \mathbf{Z}[x].$$

Proof of Theorem 1.5. Write $t = 2 + 319n$. Since $319 = 11 \cdot 29$,

$$P(t, x) \equiv P(2, x) \pmod{11}, \quad P(t, x) \equiv P(2, x) \pmod{29}.$$

The leading coefficient is 5 modulo 11 and 22 modulo 29, so neither prime divides c_t and f_t retains degree 23.

Modulo 29, the monic coefficient vector in increasing order is

$$(5, 3, 7, 15, 21, 21, 17, 9, 1, 28, 21, 25, 3, 14, 20, 28, \\ 5, 27, 24, 16, 9, 20, 18, 1).$$

Exact powering gives

$$x^{29^{23}} \equiv x \pmod{\bar{f}_{t,29}}, \quad \gcd(\bar{f}_{t,29}, x^{29} - x) = 1.$$

Rabin's criterion proves irreducibility because 23 is prime. Thus f_t is irreducible over $\mathbf{Q}$, and Frobenius supplies a 23-cycle.

Modulo 11 one has

$$\bar{f}_{t,11} = g_2 g_7 g_{14},$$

where

$$\begin{aligned} g_2 &= x^2 + 8x + 3, \\ g_7 &= x^7 + 6x^6 + 7x^5 + 6x^4 + 8x^2 + 3x + 1, \\ g_{14} &= x^{14} + 8x^{13} + 6x^{12} + 8x^{11} + 6x^{10} + 6x^9 + 3x^8 + 2x^7 \\ &\quad + 10x^6 + 3x^5 + x^4 + 8x^3 + 10x^2 + 7x + 6. \end{aligned}$$

The factors are distinct and irreducible, so Frobenius supplies an element of cycle type $(2, 7, 14)$ and order 14. Squarefreeness also proves the characteristic-zero discriminant is nonzero, and lemma 6.1 and theorem 1.3 embeds $H_t = \text{Gal}(f_t/\mathbf{Q})$ in M_{23} .

The ATLAS maximal-subgroup orders are [12, 13]

$$443520, 40320, 40320, 20160, 7920, 5760, 253.$$

Only $253 = 23 \cdot 11$ is divisible by 23, and it is odd. A subgroup containing both a 23-cycle and an element of order 14 is therefore not proper. Hence $H_t = M_{23}$. $\square$

Corollary 6.2. *The explicit primitive polynomial $f_2(x) = P(2, x)$ has Galois group M_{23} over $\mathbf{Q}$.*

6.1. Controlled ramification inside the progression. Call a family mutually independent if every finite subfamily is linearly disjoint over $\mathbf{Q}$.

Huang et al. already deduce the abstract existence of an infinite mutually independent family from their regular realization [1, Corollary 1.4(d)]. The refinement below chooses such a family inside the explicit progression of theorem 1.5 while forcing a new, controlled inertia prime at each step.

Theorem 6.3. *Among the splitting fields of f_t with $t \equiv 2 \pmod{319}$ there is an infinite mutually independent collection of M_{23} -extensions. More precisely, outside a finite set of primes, if $q \nmid 319$ and*

$$t \equiv 2 \pmod{319}, \quad v_q(t) = 1,$$

then inertia at q is generated by an element of class $2A$.

Proof. Beckmann's specialization inertia theorem [14, Proposition 4.2], applied at $T = 0$, says that away from finitely many primes, meeting the branch point with multiplicity m produces inertia conjugate to $\langle g^m \rangle$ for local monodromy g . Enlarge this exceptional set to contain 23. If $v_q(t) = 1$, then $T^2 + 23$ is a unit at the specialization, and the inertia group is the class-2A group $\langle g \rangle$.

The Chinese remainder theorem gives

$$t \equiv 2 \pmod{319}, \quad t \equiv q \pmod{q^2}.$$

Choose each new q outside the bad set and the ramified primes of all previous fields. The new field ramifies at q while the preceding fields do not, so the fields are pairwise distinct.

For mutual independence, suppose $L_1, \dots, L_r$ are linearly disjoint and $K_r = L_1 \cdots L_r$, with Galois group M_{23}^r . For a new field L , $K_r \cap L$ is Galois over $\mathbf{Q}$. Simplicity of M_{23} makes it either $\mathbf{Q}$ or L . In the latter case a surjection $M_{23}^r \twoheadrightarrow M_{23}$ must factor through one coordinate: the

coordinate images are commuting normal subgroups, and simplicity with trivial center permits only one nontrivial image. Then L equals a previous L_i , contradicting distinctness. Hence $K_r \cap L = \mathbf{Q}$. $\square$

Exact computation 6.4 (A second certified field). The integer

$$3830 \equiv 2 \pmod{319}, \quad 3830 \equiv 5 \pmod{25}$$

lies in the progression and meets $T = 0$ 5-adically with multiplicity one. Over $\mathbf{F}_5$, the repeated part

$$\gcd(F(0, V), F_V(0, V))$$

has degree 8, is squarefree, and is coprime to $F_T(0, V)$. Exact maximal-order computations give

$$v_5(\text{Disc}(\mathbf{Q}[x]/(f_2))) = 0, \quad v_5(\text{Disc}(\mathbf{Q}[x]/(f_{3830}))) = 8.$$

Thus the $t = 3830$ splitting field ramifies at 5 while the $t = 2$ field does not. The natural degree-23 action is faithful, so the same conclusion holds for their Galois closures: inertia in the closure of the unramified root field fixes every point, hence lies in the core of a point stabilizer, which is trivial.

The local analysis and specialization theorem answer complementary questions. The branch fibre reveals the centralizer and residue arithmetic after a $2A$ collision; the progression gives smooth arithmetic fibres with the full generic group.

7. OPEN QUESTIONS

The principal open question is to prove $\epsilon(\Theta) = e_{\text{sing}}$ by specialization, independently of the certified branch-cycle matching. This requires a relative geometric realization of the two finite incidence correspondences, retaining the separate integral multiplicities $\mathcal{C}$ and T_D , and a proof that the resulting special invariant is the Frobenius or quadratic-splitting idempotent of corollary 3.14. A functorial quadratic or hermitian construction is a possible approach, not an object constructed in this paper. Ordinary nearby-cycle duality and the finite identities in section 3.6 do not establish that step. Approaches via bad reduction of three-point covers [22] or logarithmic nearby cycles [21] would still have to specify the relative objects and prove the compatibility of their multiplicities.

The local component criterion applies to any finite normal algebra over a local field's ring of integers. A separate question is when a group-theoretic invariant of other Nielsen classes can be proved to detect its residue degrees without first matching every exact cover to a branch-cycle triple.

A separate arithmetic classification problem is to classify the $2^4\text{:PSL}_3(2)$ -extensions of $\mathbf{Q}$ unramified outside $\{2, 3, 23\}$ with the constituent fields and discriminants of theorem 5.13; in particular, decide whether M is unique.

8. EXACT DATA AND CERTIFICATES

The repository accompanying this paper is

<https://github.com/research-reflexivity/frontier-math-m23-cover-investigation>.

It contains canonical JSON tables for F , P , and the pencil (J_0, J_1) . The convention for the minimal-degree equation is

$$\text{coefficients_T.then_W}[i][j] = [T^i W^j]P.$$

The polynomial has 120 nonzero coefficients and content 1; its coefficient of $T^4 W^{23}$ is

$$838610528294018704285119511337682389342017079161221371107109332287875.$$

The principal input fingerprints are

```

data/Fint_coefficients_Z.json
27dd1fd0de4f1c350f5a07ead6d5b747d7a8f34e4146ec42fa953f1536a65102
data/optimal_23_4_Z.json
cfb4185b2800744d524d87b3f08f5459cd38d42afb3787c11fa1e2aa3f25ee84
data/optimal_degree4_pencil.json
fdf571e4f47effc527e1726bdd99472be2c5e3390e45133fb3d7a3aab592619d
data/canonical_quadric_Q.json
352b978369353a1cb57a1a3f54edd6b7c024896edf78c38c1601a06f395ac943
data/hurwitz_degree23_branch_candidate.json
cfbce099e3fa867b7c5ba29aa73f02f11d386cf60b00a506d1166d4c65639f62
data/hurwitz_degree23_maps_candidate.json
86cddb314d01a9123aed0b6890fa4316b4303782b1d69563e020b6ede62a6c2a

```

The single command

```
make verify-all
```

runs the complete open-source suite. The optional target `make verify-magma` repeats the minimal-model identity, irreducibility, canonical-quadric, and unpointed 23-inertia obstruction checks in Magma, together with the twelve-embedding Hurwitz critical-fibre and sextic Galois-closure checks. The recorded environment uses SageMath 10.9 [26], GAP 4.14.0 [27], Singular 4.4.1 [28], and PARI/GP 2.17.4 [29]; the independent Magma records use version 2.29-9 [25]. The opt-in target `make verify-hurwitz-third-fiber-exact` recomputes the longer characteristic-zero resultant certificate. The similarly opt-in target `make verify-hurwitz-connector-a6` reconstructs the formal annulus associated with the ramified A_6 calculation. This local calculation does not construct a semistable Galois closure or the missing relative incidence correspondences. The target `make verify-hurwitz-frobenius-selector` checks the local decomposition and the finite-field identities in corollary 3.14.

There are different kinds of verification. The quick map verifier checks serialized coefficients and recorded ranks; the producer `scripts/reconstruct_hurwitz_degree23_maps.py`, run with `--component all --check-basepoints`, recomputes the multiplier systems and the residual base-locus saturations used in proposition 3.4. The branch-cycle summary verifier checks recorded permutations, their generated groups, Nielsen matching, and input hashes. Replaying the interval continuation requires the separate targets `certify-hurwitz-branch-cycles` and `certify-degree-one-branch-cycles`; a successful summary check is not a replay of all interval inequalities. Finally, finite group audits do not certify the relative geometric construction left open in section 7.

The main targets are:

Result	Certificate	Engine
Newton-polygon valuations, nodes, adjoint pencil	<code>verify_boundary_valuations.gp</code> , <code>verify_nodes_mod31.sing</code> , <code>verify_adjoint_mod31.py</code>	PARI, Singular, Python
Minimal equation and function-field identity	<code>verify_optimal_23_4.py</code> , <code>verify_sage.py</code> , <code>verify_optimal_23_4.m</code>	Singular, SageMath, Magma
Specialization progression and ramification	<code>verify_progression_319.*</code> , <code>verify_ramified_t3830.*</code>	Python, PARI
Transport of the fibre over $T = 0$	<code>verify_special_fibre_bridge.py</code>	SageMath

Result	Certificate	Engine
Branch cycles and Fano incidence	<code>certify_branch_cycle_description.*</code> , <code>certify_special_fibre_fano.*</code>	GAP, PARI
Affine field tower and final quadratic layer	<code>certify_special_fibre_field_tower.*</code> , <code>certify_vanishing_cycle_class.*</code>	GAP, PARI
Ramification, flags, and complex-conjugation comparison	<code>certify_special_fibre_ramification.*</code> , <code>certify_local_flag_places.*</code> , <code>certify_real_frame_cocycle.*</code>	GAP, PARI
Geometric reflection obstruction and complex-conjugation comparison	<code>certify_geometric_reflection.*</code>	GAP, Magma
Canonical quadric and ruling field	<code>verify_canonical_quadric.py</code> , <code>verify_canonical_quadric.m</code>	SageMath, Magma
Unpointed 23-inertia obstruction	<code>certify_gauss_prolongation_obstruction.g</code> , <code>certify_gauss_prolongation_obstruction.m</code>	GAP, Magma
Coordinate algebra of the Hurwitz scheme, canonical curves, and marked points	<code>verify_hurwitz_*_candidate.py</code>	SageMath
Uniform atlas cover and truncation-error bounds	<code>verify_hurwitz_tail_geometry.py</code> , <code>verify_hurwitz_tail_summary.py</code>	Arb, Acb, Python
Degree-23 ratios, third branch value, and complete passport	<code>verify_hurwitz_degree23_*.py</code> , <code>verify_hurwitz_degree23_third_fiber.sage</code> , <code>verify_hurwitz_degree23_branch.m</code> , <code>verify_hurwitz_degree23_geometry.m</code>	SageMath, Magma
Exact degree-23 eliminant and all seven branch-cycle triples	<code>verify_hurwitz_monodromy_eliminant_candidate.py</code> , <code>verify_hurwitz_branch_cycle_summary.py</code>	SageMath, Arb
Transporter invariants and component-idempotent descent	<code>certify_hurwitz_relative_transporter.g</code> , <code>verify_hurwitz_relative_transporter.py</code>	GAP, SageMath
Galois closure and six-point permutation action	<code>verify_hurwitz_galois_closure.*</code>	SageMath, PARI, Magma
Local decomposition group and pointed reductions at 23	<code>verify_hurwitz_local_23.py</code> , <code>verify_hurwitz_pointed_23.py</code>	SageMath
Frobenius and quadratic-splitting idempotent	<code>verify_hurwitz_frobenius_selector.py</code>	SageMath

Result	Certificate	Engine
Finite identities and local obstructions to a specialization comparison	notes/certify_ade_gluings_marker.py, notes/certify_wild_parameter_orientation.py, notes/audit_lifted_trace_fano_affine_incidence.g, notes/audit_fano_affine_odd_fixed_point_lemma.g, notes/audit_raw_lifted_trace_node_boundary.g, notes/audit_returned_normalizer_trace_parity.g, notes/explore_tagged_tame_boundary.g, notes/certify_pinned_tag_finite_identities.py, notes/audit_pointed_relative_bockstein.py, notes/audit_pointed_relative_bockstein.m, notes/audit_log_quadratic_orientation_line.py, notes/audit_log_quadratic_orientation_line.m	GAP, Python, Magma

Several certificate filenames predate the terminology adopted in this paper and retain exploratory strings such as `connector`, `tagged`, or `orientation`. These are filenames, not names for additional geometric structures. Likewise, `special_fibre` in those filenames refers to the characteristic-zero fibre over $T = 0$, not to the closed fibre of a model over a local base.

For the coordinate-transport certificate, SageMath reconstructs the fibres over $T = 0$ in both plane models, checks the factor multiplicities and scalar identities, proves $\gcd(J_1(0, V), H_7 R_8) = 1$, and computes the minimal polynomial of J_0/J_1 in each residue field. Thus the certificate verifies the coordinate transport coefficient by coefficient, including regularity and residue-field generation. The largest computations in the Fano suite are the direct degree-1344 splitting-field calculation for R_8 , the comparison of the possible septic/octic Frobenius types, the 9,889 transvection primes below 10^6 , and the square-class tests at fourteen primes splitting completely in L_0 .

9. SCOPE, PROVENANCE, AND DISCLOSURE

The starting cover is not constructed in this paper. The regular M_{23} realization, its source equation, branch cycles, and the numerical computation of the seven complex covers and their Galois-fixed Nielsen class are due to Huang, Jackson, Lee, Poonen, Pries, and Zhang [1]. Their accompanying repository supplies the defining data used here [2].

The contributions of the present paper fall into four groups.

- (1) We reconstruct the coordinate algebra of the inner Hurwitz scheme, its seven canonical curves and degree-23 maps, their complete passports, and their branch cycles, and determine the S_6 Galois action on the degree-six component.
- (2) We determine the local decomposition and pointed reductions of that scheme at 23, construct the idempotent defined by the singular-point coordinate directly from those reductions, determine the descent behavior of the finite-group invariants built from transporter elements, and compare their component idempotents in the exact reconstructed algebra. We interpret the local idempotent as the complement of a Frobenius-fixed locus and as an unramified quadratic-splitting locus. We prove the local component criterion underlying this interpretation and specify why the finite incidence identities do not yet give a comparison by specialization.
- (3) On the distinguished cover, we explicitly construct the degree-4 function W whose existence and minimality were established in [1, Remark 3.4], its bidegree-(23, 4) equation, and exact certificates that it defines the same function field. We determine the arithmetic of

the fibre over $T = 0$, including its Fano incidence, affine torsor, field tower, ramification, and obstruction theory, and transport this structure to the minimal coordinate.

- (4) We prove the explicit uniform specialization theorem and controlled ramification inside its progression, and construct within that progression an infinite mutually independent family. The abstract existence of such families is already [1, Corollary 1.4(d)].

We do not reprove that the fixed Nielsen class is rational; that is a theorem of [1]. The idempotent defined by the singular-point coordinate gives a characteristic-23 criterion on the specified pointed models separating the degree-one and degree-six components of the reconstructed algebra. The comparison theorem proves its agreement with the augmentation of Θ by using the exact branch-cycle identification of all seven reconstructed maps. The Frobenius interpretation in corollary 3.14 is independent of the singular-position coordinate, but it does not remove the matching from the comparison with Θ . No relative quadratic determinant line or second specialization proof is asserted. In particular, the elementary nearby-cycle stalk retains the individual sheets, and the unrestricted coefficient Bockstein calculation does not recover the integral quadratic invariant.

The third branch fibre of the six conjugate maps is verified exactly in characteristic zero and independently in all twelve residue embeddings of a completely split prime. This distinction matters: numerical and lattice reconstruction discover the coefficients, while the subsequent exact elimination and branch-cycle certificates identify the covers.

The discovery and drafting process used substantial AI assistance. The computational evidence and the scope of each verification are described in section 8; these checks do not certify the unresolved relative geometric construction.

Acknowledgements. This work analyzes the construction of Huang, Jackson, Lee, Poonen, Pries, and Zhang and depends on their making the defining data publicly available in the repository cited as [2].

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